The Planted Oar

Nostic Ontology, Sēmatic Selfhood, and the Ethics of Elected Finitude in Homer's Odyssey *and Its Speculative Afterlives*



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Abstract

οὐδ' εὐήρε' ἐρετμά, τά τε πτερὰ νηυσὶ πέλονται.

"...nor well-fitted oars, which are wings to ships."

— *Odyssey* 11.125

de' remi facemmo ali al folle volo.

"...of our oars we made wings for the mad flight."

— Dante, *Inferno* 26.125

This dissertation argues that Homer's *Odyssey* is the founding document of a *nostic* ontology—a pre-philosophical yet rigorously articulated account of the human being as the creature that elects its own limit—and that the poem's philosophical telos is neither the reunion in the olive-rooted bed nor the divinely decreed amnesty of Book 24, but an event the poem narrates only as prophecy: the oar that Teiresias commands Odysseus to carry inland until a wayfarer mistakes it for a winnowing-fan, there to be planted in the earth (11.119–137; 23.264–284). The poem itself calls that oar a wing (11.125) and its misrecognition a *sēma* (11.126). Dante, who could not read Homer, made the oars into wings for a mad flight that ends with the sea closing over the voyager (*Inferno* 26.125, 142). Between the *planted oar* and the *winged oar* the study reconstructs a bifurcation that has organized two and a half millennia of reception, and proposes a heuristic—the Ulyssean Square—that maps the four soteriological vectors the poem stages as temptations: the Nostic (return to the finite home), the Gnostic (return to a transcendent origin), the Faustian (departure without return), and the Apotheotic (deathless stasis beyond the human).

Three interlocking theses carry the argument. The first, *elected finitude*, reads Odysseus' refusal of Calypso's offer to make him "deathless and ageless all his days" (5.135–136; 5.215–224) as the founding act of humanist value, reconstructed against the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, the Indo-European economy of *kleos*, and a philosophical debate that runs from Plato's simultaneous censorship and appropriation of Achilles' shade

(*Republic* 386c, 516d) through Vernant, Williams and Nussbaum to contemporary disputes over radical life-extension. The second, *sēmatic selfhood*, contends against Snell and Auerbach that the Odyssean self is neither absent nor interior but distributed across signs—scar, bed, bow, orchard, dog, song—held and read by others. The recognition sequence of Books 16–24 is analysed as a protocol of authentication under conditions of perfect visual deception, and the contrast between the dying hound Argos and the deathless golden watchdogs of Alcinous (7.91–94; 17.290–327) is shown to encode the claim that recognition is a mortal capacity. The third, *mētic withholding*, interprets the Outis stratagem (9.366; 9.405–414) and the catastrophic self-naming that follows it (9.502–535) as a theory of the name as wound and vector, and argues, against Horkheimer and Adorno, that anonymity is survivable only because identity is held in trust elsewhere.

Subsidiary chapters situate these theses within the poem's cosmology of the human middle between the automatic and the bestial (after Vidal-Naquet, and around the solitary Homeric occurrence of *physis* at 10.303); its fractured theodicy, in which juridical, vindictive and proprietary regimes of divine causation coexist without synthesis (1.32–43; 9.528–535; 12.374–390); its Phaeacian techno-utopia of self-steering ships that lack a *kybernētēs* yet "know the thoughts and minds of men" (8.555–563), petrified at the threshold of Ithaca (13.125–187) and here read as the matrix of speculative fiction from Lucian, More and Swift through Butler, Verne, Wells, Clarke, Lem, Le Guin and Kim Stanley Robinson; its political philosophy of hospitality, purgative violence and commanded oblivion (*eklēsis*, 24.484–486); and its Penelopean poetics of reversible time and aesthetic theodicy (8.577–580).

The dissertation concludes by proposing a *critical nostics*: an ethics that retains the planted oar's consecration of limit while refusing the purge through which the poem restores its household—Penelope's loom against Odysseus' bow. It offers this ethics as an untimely resource for an age that once more stands before Calypso's offer (radical life-extension), the Phaeacian ship (artificial systems that model human intention), and the Pillars of Heracles (planetary boundaries). The human being, on this reading, is the animal that knows where to plant its oar.

Note on Texts, Translations, and Conventions

The Greek text of the *Odyssey* is cited from T. W. Allen's Oxford Classical Text (2nd ed., 1917–1919), checked against M. L. West's Teubner edition (2017); the *Iliad* is cited from Monro and Allen (3rd ed., 1920). References follow the standard book-and-line numeration (thus 11.125 = Book 11, line 125). All translations from Greek, Latin, Italian, French and German are the author's own unless otherwise indicated; modern copyrighted works are paraphrased rather than quoted at length.

Greek is transliterated with macrons for eta and omega (*nostos*, *sēma*, *mētis*, *eklēsis*), while conventional Latinized spellings are retained for proper names (Odysseus, Calypso, Alcinous, Teiresias). Ancient authors and works are abbreviated according to the *Oxford Classical Dictionary*; Presocratic fragments follow Diels–Kranz (DK); Hesiod follows West; the *Epic of Gilgamesh* follows the tablet-and-line numeration of George (2003); the Egyptian narratives follow Lichtheim (1973; 1976). Modern scholarship is cited by author and date, with full references in the Selected Bibliography.



INTRODUCTION

Two Oars

The *Odyssey* ends twice: once in the bed whose post is a living olive, and once—never narrated, only foretold—in a field far from the sea where an oar is driven into the ground. This dissertation argues that the second ending is the poem's philosophical telos, and that the history of Western thought about limit, knowledge and home can be written as a quarrel between that planted oar and the winged oar of Dante's Ulysses.

I.1 *The Crux of the Two Oars*

Teiresias' prophecy in the Nekyia contains, within nineteen verses, the poem's entire philosophy of the end:

> ἔρχεσθαι δὴ ἔπειτα λαβὼν εὐῆρες ἐρετμόν, 121
> εἰς ὅ κε τοὺς ἀφίκηαι οἳ οὐκ ἴσασι θάλασσαν 122
> ἀνέρες, οὐδέ θ' ἅλεσσι μεμιγμένον εἶδαρ ἔδουσιν· 123
> οὐδ' ἄρα τοί γ' ἴσασι νέας φοινικοπαρήους 124
> οὐδ' εὐήρε' ἐρετμά, τά τε πτερὰ νηυσὶ πέλονται. 125
> σῆμα δέ τοι ἐρέω μάλ' ἀριφραδές, οὐδέ σε λήσει. 126
>
> (11.121–126)

"Then go forth, taking a well-fitted oar, until you reach men who do not know the sea and eat no food mixed with salt; they know nothing of crimson-cheeked ships, nor of well-fitted oars, which are wings to ships. And I will tell you a sign, very clear, and it will not escape you." The sign is a misreading. A wayfarer will say that Odysseus carries an *athērēloigos*, a "chaff-destroyer," a winnowing-fan, upon his shoulder (11.127–128). There he is to fix the oar in the earth, sacrifice a ram, a bull and a boar to Poseidon, return home, offer hecatombs to all the gods in order, and await a death that will come *ex halos*—"out of the sea" or "away from the sea," the preposition suspended between origin and separation—gentle, in sleek old age, among a prosperous people (11.129–137). The passage is repeated almost verbatim in the bedchamber of Book 23 (23.264–284), at the precise moment of reunion, so that the poem's culminating intimacy is framed by the announcement of a further departure.

Criticism has treated the prophecy as a folktale fossil (Hansen 1977), as a device for reconciling the hero with Poseidon, or as a coda the poem declines to narrate. Three features warrant treating it instead as the poem's telos. First, the oar is named a wing (*pteron*) in the very sentence that prescribes its planting: the instrument of flight is identified as such only to be grounded. Second, the event that ends seafaring is designated a *sēma*, the poem's master term for sign, token and tomb; its introductory formula recurs verbatim at *Iliad* 23.326, where Nestor describes the turning-post of the chariot race, which may be, he adds, the tomb of a man long dead (23.331). Third, the sign consists in a misrecognition: the voyager's instrument becomes intelligible only as an agricultural one, and its meaning as a wing dies at the frontier of salt.

Some two millennia later Dante, who had no Greek and knew Ulysses only through Latin intermediaries, gave the figure its antithetical end. His Ulysses, unmoved by "the sweetness of a son, nor reverence for an aged father, nor the due love that should have gladdened Penelope" (*Inferno* 26.94–96), passes the Pillars of Heracles: *de' remi facemmo ali al folle volo*, "of our oars we made wings for the mad flight" (26.125). Within sight of the mountain of Purgatory a whirlwind strikes the prow, and the canto ends *infin che 'l mar fu sovra noi richiuso*, "until the sea had closed above us" (26.142). The convergence is exact and, so far as the history of transmission permits us to say, uncaused: both texts call the oars wings, and the coincidence of line numbers is chance. The planted oar and the winged oar name the two great answers that Western thought has given to a question the *Odyssey* first poses with philosophical seriousness: what is the end of a voyage, and what kind of being must ask?

ODYSSEY 11.125



τά τε πτερὰ νηυσὶ πέλονται
which are wings to ships

INFERNO 26.125



de' remi facemmo ali al folle volo
of our oars we made wings for the mad flight

FIGURE 1

The two oars

Left, the oar Teiresias bids Odysseus carry inland and plant among people who take it for a winnowing-fan (11.121–137). Right, the oars Dante's Ulysses makes into wings for the mad flight (*Inferno* 26.125). Both texts call the oars wings, at the same line number. In the manner of black-figure.

I.2 *Philosophy Before Philosophy: Method*

To call the *Odyssey* a philosophical text is anachronistic, and the anachronism is instructive. The poem antedates the first Ionian inquirers into *physis*, and it knows nothing of *philosophia*, a word whose verb first appears in Herodotus as the description of Solon's travels undertaken "for the sake of seeing" (θεωρίης εἵνεκεν, Hdt. 1.30.2)—that is, as the description of an Odyssean mode of life. Havelock (1963) argued that Homeric epic functioned as the encyclopedia of an oral culture, so that Plato's assault on the poets was a war between two technologies of cultural memory. Snell (1946) argued that the Homeric mind lacked the unified concepts of soul, decision and self that philosophy would discover; Dodds (1951) charted the passage from a shame culture toward a guilt culture.

Williams (1993) dismantled the progressivist premise of these accounts, showing that the Homeric agent already possesses the essential apparatus of deliberation, intention, responsibility and shame. The present study inherits that anti-progressivism and presses it further. The *Odyssey* does not merely contain the raw materials of later philosophy; it articulates, in narrative and figural form, positions that later philosophy re-

stated conceptually—often without acknowledging the debt, and sometimes by inverting it.

The method is the one Nietzsche announced at Basel in 1869 when he inverted Seneca's complaint that "what was philosophy has become philology" (*quae philosophia fuit, facta philologia est*, *Ep.* 108.23) into the program *philosophia facta est quae philologia fuit*. Three procedures are combined. A lexical-semantic philology reconstructs the poem's conceptual vocabulary—*nostos*, *noos*, *mētis*, *sēma*, *physis*, *xenia*, *kleos*, *gastēr*, *homophrosynē*, *eklēsis*—from its formulaic distribution, on the premise that in an oral-derived poem the formula is a unit of thought as well as of meter (Parry 1971; Lord 1960; Nagy 1979). A comparative-genealogical method situates the poem within its Indo-European and Near Eastern horizons (Watkins 1995; Burkert 1992; West 1997), not to reduce it to its sources but to measure its swerve from them. A reception-theoretical method treats the history of interpretation as constitutive of meaning rather than accidental to it (Jauss 1967; Martindale 1993): what Plato, Plotinus, Dante, Bacon, Joyce, Adorno and Levinas made of the *Odyssey* belongs to its philosophical content as corollaries belong to a theorem.

Because the argument extends to speculative fiction, one further premise must be stated. Following Suvin (1979), speculative fiction is understood as the literature of cognitive estrangement: it displaces a world from the empirical by means of a *novum* and then submits that world to rational scrutiny. The thought experiments of analytic philosophy—Parfit's teletransporter, Williams's Makropulos case, Clark and Chalmers's notebook-bearing Otto—are fictions of exactly this kind. So, this study argues, are the Apologoi of Books 9–12, in which Odysseus narrates to the Phaeacians a world of floating islands, one-eyed autarchs, transformed bodies and omniscient singers. Speculative fiction and philosophy are treated here as sibling genres descended from a common Odyssean ancestor.

I.3 *The Argument in Seven Theses*

I Elected finitude. The founding act of the poem is Odysseus' refusal of a perfect immortality—not the Tithonian curse of deathlessness without youth, but the "deathless and ageless" existence of the gods (5.136)—in favor of a mortal woman he concedes to be lesser in form (5.215–224). Mortality is thereby converted from a fate suffered into a limit chosen, and value in the poem becomes a function of that limit.

II Sēmatic selfhood. The Odyssean self is neither the absent self of Snell nor the interior self of Augustine and Descartes, but a distributed constellation of

signs—bodily, artifactual, arboreal, animal and narrative—held and read by others. Recognition is reading: Penelope knows her husband "having recognized the signs" (σήματ' ἀναγνούσῃ, 23.206), and ἀναγιγνώσκω will become the Greek verb for reading.

III Mētic withholding. The Outis stratagem is possible only because identity is held in trust elsewhere. The name is a wound—the poem derives *Odysseus* from *odyssomai*, "to be wroth with" (19.406–409)—and a vector of curse; anonymity is the art of a finite agent who cannot afford to be fully present.

IV The human middle. The poem's cosmology situates the human between the automatic—gods, golden-age peoples, Hephaestean machines—and the bestial, defining it by labor, sacrifice, bread and the knowledge of *physis*, a word that occurs in Homer only once, as the nature of the herb that preserves human form (10.303).

V Fractured theodicy. Three incommensurable regimes of divine causation—juridical (Zeus), vindictive (Poseidon) and proprietary-cosmic (Helios)—coexist without synthesis; an aesthetic theodicy (8.577–580) supplements but does not resolve them.

VI The Phaeacian threshold. The speculative imagination is born in the poem as a post-scarcity, automated utopia that the hero must pass through and that is petrified behind him (13.125–187). Speculative fiction is, in this precise sense, the Phaeacian genre.

VII The planted oar. The poem's telos is the voluntary conversion of the instrument of departure into the sign of its end—a *sēma* that is at once turning-post, tomb and misreading. Against it stands the winged oar of Faustian modernity.

Together these theses constitute what this study calls a *nostic* ontology. The adjective is coined from *nostos* with deliberate assonance to *gnostic*. The nostic return is to the finite, the particular, the shared and the mortal; the gnostic return is to a transcendent origin from which the world is exile. The coinage recovers a possibility the dominant reception has obscured: that the Odyssean homecoming is neither a regression to the Same (Levinas), nor an allegory of the soul's flight from matter (Plotinus), nor the bourgeois subject's self-preservation through self-renunciation (Horkheimer and Adorno), but a philosophically coherent affirmation of limit.

1.4 *The Ulyssean Square*

To map the reception, the study adapts Greimas's semiotic square (1966) into a heuristic generated by two oppositions. The first concerns the vector of the journey: return or departure. The second concerns the horizon of home: immanent (earth, body, household, polity) or transcendent (the divine, the intelligible, the posthuman). Immanent return defines the Nostic position; transcendent return, the Gnostic; immanent departure, the Faustian; transcendent stasis, the Apotheotic.

The *Odyssey* alone among the texts examined stages all four positions as temptations within its own narrative—Ithaca and the bed; the shades of Hades and the prophet whose mind alone survives death (10.492–495); the Sirens' offer of total knowledge (12.189–191); Calypso's offer of deathlessness—and chooses the first. The square is drawn and populated in Chapter 9.

1.5 *Plan of the Work*

Chapter 1 reconstructs the pre-philosophical archive from which the poem's ideas derive: Indo-European poetics of fame and return, the Mesopotamian and Egyptian literature of the far journey, Hesiod's Metis, Muses and golden age, the *Iliad* as foil, and the Argonautic and Cyclic substrates. Chapter 2 analyzes polytropic intelligence—*mētis*, the lying tales, the economy of disclosure—and the Outis stratagem. Chapter 3 develops the theory of sēmatic selfhood through the scar, the bed, the bow, the orchard and the dog. Chapter 4 reconstructs elected finitude against *Gilgamesh*, the poem's internal economy of immortality, and its speculative revisions from the *Telegony* to Madeline Miller.

Chapter 5 maps the cosmology of the human middle, the first appearance of *physis*, the fractured theodicy and the philosophy of the belly. Chapter 6 reads Phaeacia as the first techno-utopia and the matrix of speculative fiction. Chapter 7 treats the political philosophy of hospitality, violence, slavery, nostalgia and amnesty. Chapter 8 develops a Penelopean poetics and an ethics of listening. Chapter 9 traces the bifurcation of the two oars through the history of reception. The Conclusion returns to the planted oar and proposes a critical nostics.



CHAPTER ONE

The Pre-Philosophical Archive: Sources, Substrates, and the Anonymous Poet

The ideas embedded in the *Odyssey* have no single originator. They are the sediment of an Indo-European poetics of fame and return, a Near Eastern literature of the far journey, a Hesiodic theology of cunning and fiction, a folk repertoire of homecomings and impostures, and an epic tradition in which the *Iliad* already stood as the dominant—and therefore contestable—paradigm. This chapter reconstructs that archive in order to measure the poem's swerve from it: what the *Odyssey* inherits, it almost always turns.

1.1 *Homer as Outis: The Anonymity of Origin*

The poem begins by withholding a name. The *Iliad* names its hero in its first line (Πηληϊάδεω Ἀχιλῆος, *Il.* 1.1); the *Odyssey* asks the Muse for "the man" (ἄνδρα, 1.1), qualifies him with an adjective—*polytropos*, "of many turns"—and defers his name until the council of the gods (1.21). The proem thus enacts at the level of narration the stratagem its hero will enact in the Cyclops' cave: identity is given first as function and only later as name. Even the first narrative fact about him is a privation. He alone is "in want of his return and his wife" (νόστου κεχρημένον ἠδὲ γυναικός, 1.13), so that the man is introduced by what he lacks before he is introduced by who he is.

The anonymity of the hero is matched by that of the poet. "Homer" is, for modern scholarship, less an author than a problem. Vico's "discovery of the true Homer" (*Scienza Nuova*, 1744, Book III) dissolved the individual poet into a poetic character of the Greek peoples singing their own history. Wolf's *Prolegomena ad Homerum* (1795) argued that poems of such length could not have been composed without writing and must have been assembled later. The nineteenth century divided into Analysts, who quarried the text for strata (Kirchhoff 1879; Wilamowitz 1884), and Unitarians, who defended a single architect; Neoanalysis (Kakridis 1949) reconstructed lost pre-Homeric poems behind the extant ones.

Milman Parry's demonstration that the diction is a system of formulae refined over generations of oral performance (Parry 1971), confirmed by Albert Lord's fieldwork among South Slavic singers (Lord 1960), relocated the origin of the poems from an individual to a tradition. Gregory Nagy's evolutionary model describes a gradual crystallization through performance until a relatively fixed text emerged (Nagy 1996). M. L. West, at the other pole, argues for a single literate poet distinct from the poet of the *Iliad* and working well into the seventh century (West 2014). Linguistic statistics place the poem after the *Iliad* and in the neighborhood of Hesiod (Janko 1982).

Whatever position one adopts, the *Odyssey* reaches us as a text whose originator is, in the strict sense, Nobody: an authorial Outis whose individuality has been distributed across a tradition. Samuel Butler's *The Authoress of the Odyssey* (1897) is best read as a speculative attempt to give that anonymous origin a face—that of a young woman of Trapani who wrote herself into the poem as Nausicaa. The hypothesis is philologically untenable and hermeneutically prophetic: it anticipates a century of feminist reception that culminates in what is widely described as the first published English translation of the poem by a woman (Wilson 2017).

The poem supplies its own theory of authorship in the plea of the bard Phemius, who claims to be self-taught (αὐτοδίδακτος) and in the same breath says that a god "made songs of every kind grow" in his mind (θεὸς δέ μοι ἐν φρεσὶν οἵμας / παντοίας ἐνέφυσεν, 22.347–348). Originality and tradition, self and god, are not alternatives but co-implicated. The poem's account of where songs come from is already what Chapter 3 will call sēmatic: authorship is distributed, and the singer is the site at which a tradition becomes a voice.

1.2 *The Indo-European Inheritance: Kleos, Nostos, Noos*

The deepest stratum of the poem's conceptual vocabulary is Indo-European. The formula *kleos aphthiton*, "imperishable fame," corresponds etymologically to the Vedic *śrávas …ákṣitam* (*Rigveda* 1.9.7), a correspondence noted by Adalbert Kuhn in 1853

and developed by Schmitt (1967), Nagy (1974) and Watkins (1995) into evidence for a shared poetics in which song confers on the hero the only immortality available to mortals. The *Iliad* formulates the decisive alternative in Achilles' own words: if he stays and fights, "my return has perished, but my fame will be imperishable" (ὄλετο μέν μοι νόστος, ἀτὰρ κλέος ἄφθιτον ἔσται, *Il.* 9.413); if he sails home, his fame perishes but his life will be long (9.414–416). *Nostos* and *kleos* stand in exclusive disjunction.

The *Odyssey* is the poem written to dissolve that disjunction. Its hero announces himself to the Phaeacians as the man whose fame "reaches heaven" (9.20), but the fame he claims is the fame of a returner, and the *kleos* that "will never perish" at the end of the poem belongs not to him but to the excellence of Penelope (24.196–198). The return becomes the matter of fame, and fame redistributes itself from the battlefield to the household.

Douglas Frame (1978) argued that *nostos* and *noos*, "return" and "mind," derive from a single root *nes-, whose core meaning he reconstructs as "return to light and life." The Vedic cognate survives in the Nāsatyā, the twin Aśvins who rescue the drowning Bhujyu and carry him home in vessels the hymn describes as animate, coursing through the air away from the waters (*Rigveda* 1.116.3–5). If the etymology holds, the proem's pairing of the man who "knew the mind" (νόον ἔγνω, 1.3) of many peoples with the man who strove for "the return of his companions" (νόστον ἑταίρων, 1.5) is not a rhetorical parallel but a figura etymologica at the root of the poem: the mind is the faculty of return.

The rescue of a castaway by ensouled ships across a sea that figures death will reappear in the Phaeacian convoy that bears Odysseus home in a sleep "unwaking, sweetest, most like death" (13.80). Chapters 4 and 6 return to that passage.

1.3 *The Near Eastern Horizon*

Walter Burkert's *Orientalizing Revolution* (1984; English 1992) and M. L. West's *East Face of Helicon* (1997) established that Archaic Greek poetry was composed within a Mediterranean contact zone in which Mesopotamian, Levantine, Anatolian and Egyptian narratives circulated through trade, migration and the craftsmen who carried the alphabet westward. The *Odyssey* is the Greek poem most saturated with this horizon.

The *Epic of Gilgamesh* in its Standard Babylonian recension, attributed to the scholar Sîn-lēqi-unninni, opens with the incipit *ša nagba īmuru*, "he who saw the Deep," and a prologue presenting its hero as one who traveled the distant road, grew weary, found rest, and set down all his toils on a tablet of stone. The *Odyssey*'s proem presents the man who wandered much, "saw the cities of many men and knew their mind," and suffered many pains at sea (1.1–4). In both poems the hero is first a seer and knower, and only then a sufferer; in both, wisdom is the residue of distance.

The narrative parallels, catalogued by West, are dense. Ishtar's proposal to Gilgamesh, rejected with a catalogue of the lovers she ruined (Tablet VI), anticipates Calypso's complaint against the gods' jealousy of goddesses who take mortal lovers (5.118–129) and Hermes' warning that Circe may leave Odysseus "unmanned" (*ἀνήνορα*, 10.301). Siduri, the ale-wife at the edge of the sea, and Utnapishtim on his island beyond the Waters of Death correspond to Circe and Calypso, figures at the world's rim who withhold, advise and release. Urshanabi the boatman corresponds to the Phaeacian convoy, and the punting-poles Gilgamesh cuts for the crossing to the raft Odysseus builds with Calypso's tools (5.234–261).

The deeper relation, however, is antithetical. Gilgamesh seeks immortality and fails; Odysseus is offered it and refuses. Chapter 4 argues that the *Odyssey* is, in this precise sense, an anti-*Gilgamesh*.

Egypt supplies two further templates. The *Tale of the Shipwrecked Sailor* (Middle Kingdom; Papyrus Hermitage 1115) tells of the sole survivor of a wreck, cast upon an island ruled by a gigantic serpent who receives him kindly, tells him of a catastrophe of his own—a falling star that burned his kin—counsels endurance, foretells his rescue, and sends him home laden with gifts, adding that the island will become water and never be seen again. The correspondence with the Phaeacian episode is close: sole survivor, island of a benevolent power beyond the known world, an exchange of narratives of loss, gifts, convoy home, and the subsequent withdrawal of the island from the human map (compare 13.125–187).

The Egyptian tale is framed, moreover, by a scene of failed consolation: the sailor tells his story to an anxious official, who rejects it with a bitter proverb about watering at dawn a bird that will be slaughtered by morning. The earliest frame-tale in the Mediterranean record thus stages the possibility that narrative may not console. The Phaeacian court, held spellbound in the shadowy hall by Odysseus' telling (11.333–334), conspicuously forecloses that possibility; Chapter 8 returns to it.

The *Story of Sinuhe* narrates an exile who prospers among foreigners in Retjenu yet longs to be buried in Egypt, and whose return is consummated by the grant of a tomb: homecoming as the right to a *sēma* in one's own earth. The *Report of Wenamun* (c. 1075 BCE) records the opposite experience—an Egyptian envoy robbed at Dor, rebuffed at Byblos, and driven by storm to Cyprus—and so documents the collapse of reciprocal hospitality in a post-imperial Mediterranean. It is in a world of that kind that *xenia* must be theologized, placed under the protection of Zeus, because no earthly power can enforce it.

The poem's own Levantine Others are the Phoenicians: traders, carriers and kidnappers who populate Odysseus' lying tales (13.272–286; 14.287–300) and Eumaeus' autobiography (15.415–484). Irad Malkin (1998) reads the poem as a product of the

"middle ground" of early Greek colonization; Carol Dougherty (2001) reads it as an exercise of the ethnographic imagination. Both converge on the claim this study adopts: the *Odyssey*'s philosophy of home is formed in, and against, a world of mobility, trade and capture.

1.4 *Hesiod: Metis Swallowed, Muses That Lie, Earth That Bears of Itself*

Hesiod, roughly contemporary with the monumental composition of the *Odyssey*, supplies three of its governing ideas. The first is theological. In the *Theogony* Zeus takes Metis, wisest of gods and mortals, as his first wife and, when she is pregnant with Athena, swallows her, so that she might devise good and evil for him from within and no son might overthrow him (*Theog.* 886–900). Detienne and Vernant (1974) read the myth as the founding charter of sovereignty: order is secured not by abolishing cunning but by incorporating it. Athena, Odysseus' patron, is the daughter of incorporated *mētis*, and when she tells him on the Ithacan shore that they "both know stratagems" (εἰδότες ἄμφω / κέρδε', 13.296–297), the alliance between goddess and hero is revealed as a filiation of intelligence.

The second idea is a theory of fiction. At the opening of the *Theogony* the Muses declare: ἴδμεν ψεύδεα πολλὰ λέγειν ἐτύμοισιν ὁμοῖα, / ἴδμεν δ' εὖτ' ἐθέλωμεν ἀληθέα γηρύσασθαι—"we know how to say many false things like true ones, and we know, when we wish, how to utter true things" (*Theog.* 27–28). The *Odyssey* transfers this self-description from the goddesses to its hero: telling his Cretan tale to Penelope, Odysseus "made many false things like true ones" (ἴσκε ψεύδεα πολλὰ λέγων ἐτύμοισιν ὁμοῖα, 19.203). The first Greek theory of fiction migrates from the divine to the human, and its first human practitioner is Odysseus.

The third idea is the golden age. In the *Works and Days* the golden race lived like gods, free of toil and old age, while the grain-giving earth bore fruit "of itself" (αὐτομάτη, *Op.* 117–118). The *Odyssey* distributes these golden-age features between two peoples it places beyond the human world: the Cyclopes, whose land yields wheat, barley and vines unsown and unplowed (9.108–111), and the Phaeacians, whose orchard fruits never fail or perish, winter or summer (7.114–121). Chapters 5 and 6 show that the poem thereby converts Hesiod's myth of a lost past into a critique of an imagined elsewhere.

Hesiod supplies, finally, a myth of the container. Pandora lifts the lid of the jar, releasing evils into the world, while Hope alone remains beneath its lip (*Op.* 90–99). The *Odyssey*'s counterpart is the leather bag in which Aeolus binds the winds (10.19–27): the companions, suspecting that it holds gold and silver (10.34–45), open it within

sight of Ithaca, and the released winds drive the ships back to the floating island. Both myths tie the human condition to an unsealed vessel, and both locate the catastrophe in a suspicion about what a container holds.

1.5 *The* Iliad *as Foil and the Redistribution of Kleos*

Ancient criticism already read the two poems as a contrast. Pseudo-Longinus compared the *Odyssey* to the setting sun, possessing grandeur without intensity, and called it a kind of comedy of character (*De sublimitate* 9.11–15). Aristotle judged the *Iliad* simple and full of suffering, the *Odyssey* complex—"for recognition runs through it"—and ethical (*Poetics* 1459b13–16). He also observed that its double structure, with opposite fates for the good and the wicked, pleases the weakness of audiences and belongs rather to comedy (1453a30–39). The *Odyssey* knows its own novelty: Telemachus defends Phemius' song of the Achaeans' bitter returns on the ground that men praise most "the song that is newest to those who hear it" (1.351–352).

Pietro Pucci (1987) showed how systematically the *Odyssey* rewrites Iliadic diction to redefine heroic excellence. The Iliadic Odysseus already carries the seeds of the later one: Antenor remembers his words falling like winter snowflakes (*Il.* 3.221–223); he leads the night raid in which deception and darkness replace frontal combat (*Il.* 10); and he insists, against Achilles, that the army must eat before it fights, since no man can fight all day fasting (*Il.* 19.155–183). Achilles refuses food, and Athena instils nectar and ambrosia into his breast (19.347–354).

The contrast is programmatic. The Iliadic hero who refuses bread is fed by a goddess with the food of the deathless; the Odyssean hero argues for the belly. Chapter 5 develops the philosophy of the *gastēr* that this exchange anticipates.

The decisive Odyssean revision concerns *kleos* itself. In the second Nekyia, Agamemnon's shade pronounces Odysseus blessed for having won a wife of great excellence: the fame of Penelope's virtue will never perish, the gods will make a lovely song about her for mortals, whereas Clytemnestra will be a "hateful song" (στυγερὴ ἀοιδή) among men (24.192–202). Imperishable fame—the Indo-European prize of the warrior who dies young—is awarded to a living woman for the intelligence of her fidelity. The *Odyssey* does not abolish the economy of *kleos*; it changes its currency.

1.6 *Substrates: Argo, Cycle, Folktale*

The poem is written over earlier voyage poetry. Circe tells Odysseus that only one seafaring ship has passed the Wandering Rocks, "the Argo known to all" (Ἀργὼ πᾶσι μέλουσα, 12.70), sailing from Aeëtes, whom the poem makes Circe's brother (10.137).

Karl Meuli (1921) hypothesized that the wanderings adapt a pre-Homeric *Argonautica*, and details such as the spring Artakie in the land of the Laestrygonians (10.108), a name the Argonautic tradition places near Cyzicus, support the view that the *Odyssey* is a palimpsest of the far journey.

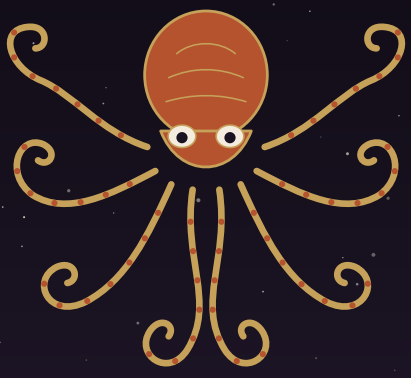
The poem also stands within the Epic Cycle. The *Nostoi* narrated the returns of the other Achaeans, including the murder of Agamemnon that the *Odyssey* invokes as its constant counter-paradigm. The *Telegony*, attributed to Eugammon of Cyrene and known through Proclus' summary, carried the story beyond the *Odyssey*'s end: Odysseus journeys to Thesprotia, is killed unknowingly by Telegonus, his son by Circe, and Circe then makes Penelope and Telemachus immortal, whereupon Telegonus marries Penelope and Telemachus marries Circe. The earliest sequel to the poem thus reverses its founding choice; Chapter 4 analyzes the reversal.

Beneath epic lies folktale. The homecoming of a husband who arrives in disguise as his wife is about to remarry is an international type (ATU 974, The Homecoming Husband), attested from medieval ballads to Russian *byliny*. The motif of the sailor who walks inland with an oar until someone asks what it is survives, as William Hansen (1977) documented, in modern Greek legends attached to the prophet Elias, which explain why his chapels crown the mountain summits. The planted oar is thus older and more widely diffused than the poem. What the poem adds is philosophical: it names the oar a wing, designates its misreading a *sēma*, and places that sign at the end of a life.

1.7 *From Archive to Swerve*

Read against its archive, the *Odyssey* consistently turns what it inherits. From the Indo-European tradition it takes the disjunction of fame and return and dissolves it. From *Gilgamesh* it takes the far journey to the edge of mortality and inverts its goal. From the *Shipwrecked Sailor* it takes the benevolent island and the consoling tale, and closes the island behind the hero. From Hesiod it takes incorporated cunning, the Muses' fiction and the self-bearing earth, and converts the last into a critique of utopia. From the *Iliad* it takes *kleos* and changes its bearer.

The originators of the poem's ideas are many; the swerve is its own. The chapters that follow attend to that swerve, beginning with the faculty that makes it possible: the turning mind.



CHAPTER TWO

Polytropos: Mētis, Noos, and the Economy of Disclosure

Odysseus' intelligence is a theory of how a finite agent survives among superior powers: it works obliquely, discloses identity in measured stages, and treats the name as both weapon and wound. This chapter reconstructs that theory from the poem's lexicon, its genealogy of cunning, the Outis stratagem and its catastrophic sequel, the lying tales, and the graduated unconcealment of the hero's identity, and it closes by contesting the most influential modern critique of Odyssean reason.

2.1 *The Lexicon of the Turning Mind*

Odysseus is the most heavily epitheted mind in Greek poetry: *polytropos* (1.1; 10.330), *polymētis* (the commonest), *polymēchanos*, *poikilomētis*, *polytlas*, *talasiphrōn*, *echephrōn*. The compound in the first line has generated the poem's oldest interpretive dispute. Antisthenes, as preserved in a scholion attributed to Porphyry on 1.1, rejected the pejorative reading—"unstable, of many characters"—and glossed the *tropoi* as modes of speech: the wise man is polytropic because he knows how to fit discourse to every audience, as Pythagoras was said to have addressed children, women and magistrates each in their own register. Polytropy becomes the virtue of the philosopher-rhetor.

Plato's *Hippias Minor* (364c–376c) stages the opposite valuation and then subverts it. Hippias, quoting Achilles' hatred of the man who hides one thing in his heart and says another (*Il.* 9.312–313), declares Achilles "true and simple" and Odysseus "polytropic and false." Socrates argues that the false man must be the man capable of falsehood, hence the man who knows the truth, so that the true man and the false man are the same; and he extracts the scandalous corollary that the voluntary wrongdoer is better than the involuntary. The dialogue leaves the paradox suspended, as if Odysseus had infected the argument with his own versatility.

The Latin tradition begins, literally, with this adjective. The first line of Latin literature, Livius Andronicus' translation of the *Odyssey*, renders the proem *Virum mihi, Camena, insece versutum*—"tell me, Camena, of the man who turns." Horace domesticated the figure as the exemplary sage who "saw the customs and the cities of many men" (*Ars Poetica* 141–142; *Epistles* 1.2.19–20). Emily Wilson's choice of "complicated" for *polytropos* (2017) is a recent instance of a translation that is also a philosophical decision: it returns the word to its semantic openness, declining to decide between versatility and duplicity.

2.2 *Mētis: Intelligence Under Constraint*

Detienne and Vernant (1974) defined *mētis* as a type of intelligence engaged in practice, applied to shifting and ambiguous situations that resist measurement and exact calculation; it works by detour, disguise and the reversal of forces, and its emblematic animals are the fox and the octopus. Its domains are navigation, hunting, fishing, weaving, medicine and rhetoric. Philosophy, from Plato onward, largely suppressed *mētis* in favor of *epistēmē*, stable knowledge of what does not change. The *Odyssey* is the great poem of the intelligence philosophy chose to forget.

Odysseus' *mētis* is first of all technical. He builds his raft from twenty trees with Calypso's axe, adze and augers, laying out its floor as wide as a skilled carpenter lays the floor of a broad merchantman (5.234–261). He hardens a stake of olive in fire and drives it into the Cyclops' eye, an act the poem describes through two technological similes: a shipwright boring a timber with a drill that companions spin with a thong, and a smith quenching an axe or adze in cold water so that it hisses (9.383–394). Violence against the monstrous is figured as craft. When the sea tears him from the Phaeacian rock, the skin stripped from his hands is compared to the pebbles that cling to the suckers of an octopus dragged from its lair (5.432–435): the hero is assimilated, in extremity, to the animal of *mētis* itself.

The poem supplies a genealogy of cunning. Odysseus' maternal grandfather Autolycus "surpassed all men in thievery and in the oath" (κλεπτοσύνῃ θ' ὅρκῳ τε, 19.395–396),

a gift of Hermes, god of boundaries, exchange and theft; it is Autolycus who names the child (19.406–409). His patron Athena is, as Chapter 1 showed, the daughter of Metis swallowed by Zeus. *Mētis* descends to Odysseus from a thief and a perjurer on one side and from incorporated sovereignty on the other.

The philosophical significance of this genealogy is that *mētis* is the intelligence of limit. Unlike *epistēmē*, which aspires to a view from nowhere and a mastery outside time, *mētis* presupposes the agent's inferiority of force: it is the reason of the weaker party in a field defined by others. Michel de Certeau, drawing explicitly on Detienne and Vernant, defined "tactics" as the art of the weak, which operates within the space of the other, lacks a proper place of its own, and must seize the occasion as it passes (de Certeau 1980). The Odysseus of the wanderings is the archetypal tactician: a man without a place, working on other people's islands. *Mētis* is thus the epistemic correlate of elected finitude—the form of reason proper to a being that does not claim divinity.

2.3 *Outis: The Name as Wound*

The poem gives two etymologies of its hero's name, both from *odyssomai*, "to be wroth with, to hate." Athena asks Zeus why he is so wroth with Odysseus (τί νύ οἱ τόσον ὠδύσαο, Ζεῦ; 1.62); Autolycus names the child because he himself comes "having been wroth with many" (ὀδυσσάμενος, 19.407–409). Poseidon, the hero recognizes, "has been wroth" with him (ὀδώδυσται, 5.423). George Dimock (1956) drew the conclusion: to be Odysseus is to be a man of odium, its object and its agent. The name is a wound before it is a title.

Hence the stratagem in the cave:

> Οὖτις ἐμοί γ' ὄνομα· Οὖτιν δέ με κικλήσκουσι. 366
>
> (9.366)

"Nobody is my name; Nobody they call me." The pun operates on two planes. *Outis* negates with *ou*; when the other Cyclopes ask whether anyone is harming the blinded giant, their conditional uses the modal negative—εἰ μὲν δὴ μή τίς σε βιάζεται, "if no one is doing you violence" (9.410)—and *mē tis* is homophonous with *mētis*. Odysseus' heart laughs "how my name and my blameless cunning had deceived" (ὡς ὄνομ' ἐξαπάτησεν ἐμὸν καὶ μῆτις ἀμύμων, 9.414). The stratagem identifies the self with its intelligence precisely by emptying it of its name.

Then the catastrophe. Once the ship is clear, Odysseus shouts back: "Cyclops, if any mortal man asks you about the shameful blinding of your eye, say that Odysseus, sacker of cities, blinded it, the son of Laertes, whose home is in Ithaca" (9.502–505). Polyphemus recalls a prophecy that he would lose his sight at the hands of Odysseus;

he had expected a tall and handsome man, and has been blinded instead by one "small, worthless and feeble" (ὀλίγος τε καὶ οὐτιδανὸς καὶ ἄκικυς, 9.515)—*outidanos*, a nobody, the adjective that echoes Outis.

His prayer to Poseidon then reproduces the boast's data with forensic exactness: let Odysseus, sacker of cities, son of Laertes, whose home is in Ithaca, never reach home—or, if he is fated to, let him come late and in misery, having lost all his companions, on another's ship, and find troubles in his house (9.528–535). Every clause is fulfilled by the plot. The curse requires the name, and it receives with the name the epithet, the patronymic and the address—the full set of what a modern registry would call identifying data. The self-naming is the poem's catastrophe.

John Peradotto (1990) read the hero as a "man in the middle voice," suspended between the name as determination—destiny, curse, prophecy—and the anonymity of open possibility. The Outis principle has a lyric afterlife that turns it into an anthropology. Warning the suitor Amphinomus, the disguised Odysseus says that nothing feebler than man does earth nourish, "for such is the mind of men on earth as the day the father of gods and men brings upon them" (τοῖος γὰρ νόος ἐστὶν ἐπιχθονίων ἀνθρώπων / οἷον ἐπ' ἦμαρ ἄγῃσι πατὴρ ἀνδρῶν τε θεῶν τε, 18.136–137). Archilochus echoes the thought (fr. 131–132 West), and Hermann Fränkel (1946) showed that *ephēmeros* means "subject to the day," not merely "short-lived."

Pindar then fuses this anthropology with the Odyssean negative: ἐπάμεροι· τί δέ τις; τί δ' οὔ τις; σκιᾶς ὄναρ / ἄνθρωπος—"creatures of a day: what is someone? what is no one? A dream of a shadow is man" (*Pythian* 8.95–96). The *ou tis* of the cave becomes a question about the human as such. The name with which Odysseus saved himself becomes the lyric definition of mortality.

2.4 *Anonymity in the Speculative Archive*

The Outis principle recurs wherever speculative fiction asks what identity costs. Jules Verne's Captain Nemo—his name the exact Latin translation of Outis—commands a self-sufficient submarine, renounces nation and name, wages a private war against imperial power, and holds his guests in a beautiful prison of science until they escape through the Maelstrom, Charybdis modernized (*Vingt mille lieues sous les mers*, 1869–70). Vernor Vinge's *True Names* (1981) makes the concealment of legal identity the condition of agency in a networked world: those whose "true names" the state discovers lose their freedom, and the plot is an Outis stratagem in cyberspace. Ursula K. Le Guin's Earthsea makes knowledge of a true name power over its bearer.

The contemporary politics of de-anonymization, profiling and data doubles extends the scene of 9.502–535: the boast that delivers name, lineage and address to a hostile

power. Édouard Glissant's claim to a "right to opacity" (*Poétique de la Relation*, 1990) supplies the political form of the Outis principle—the refusal of the colonized and the stranger to be rendered transparent to the categories of the powerful. Chapter 7 connects that right to the Homeric protocol of hospitality, which defers the question of the name until the guest has been fed.

2.5 *Fiction as Cognition: The Lying Tales*

Odysseus tells five false autobiographies on Ithaca: to Athena disguised as a shepherd (13.256–286), to Eumaeus (14.192–359), to the suitors (17.415–444), to Penelope (19.165–202), and to Laertes (24.244–279). They feature a Cretan persona, Phoenician traders, a failed raid on Egypt (14.245–286), a Thesprotian king. The narrator glosses the tale to Penelope with the formula of Hesiod's Muses: he "made many false things like true ones" (19.203).

The Phaeacian king had earlier formulated a naive epistemology of narrative. "We do not take you for a cheat or a thief, such as the black earth breeds in numbers," Alcinous tells Odysseus at the pause in his tale; "there is shapeliness upon your words, and good sense within" (σοὶ δ' ἔπι μὲν μορφὴ ἐπέων, ἔνι δὲ φρένες ἐσθλαί, 11.363–368). Aesthetic form is taken as evidence of truth. The poem ironizes the criterion: the same shapeliness belongs to the lies.

The tales are not merely protective. Each is an epistemic instrument that probes the listener's mind—the *noos* the proem says Odysseus came to know (1.3). The tale to Eumaeus tests loyalty and generosity; the tale to Penelope tests constancy; the tale to Laertes tests grief, and provokes it to the point at which concealment becomes unbearable (24.315–319). Fiction is the poem's method for knowing other minds: one learns what a person is by telling them who one is not.

The tales are also counterfactual autobiographies, possible lives the hero might have lived. In that sense they are the poem's own "lost books," and they anticipate both Lucian's *True History* (Chapter 6) and Zachary Mason's *The Lost Books of the Odyssey* (2010), which presents dozens of variant Odysseys as recovered fragments of a tradition that never fixed its hero.

The goddess's response to the first lie is the poem's theology of intelligence. Athena smiles, strokes Odysseus with her hand, takes the form of a tall and beautiful woman, and says that it would take a crafty and thievish one to surpass him in every trick, even a god (13.287–292). She cannot abandon him, she explains, because he is ἐπητής, ἀγχίνοος, ἐχέφρων—courteous in speech, quick of mind, self-possessed (13.330–332). The goddess loves the mortal for his mind.

Aristotle would generalize the principle: if the gods have any care for human affairs, it is reasonable that they delight in what is best and most akin to themselves, namely intellect, so that the wise man is most dear to the gods (*Nicomachean Ethics* 10.8, 1179a22–32). The *Odyssey*'s theology of affinity grounds divine favor in noetic resemblance rather than in lineage or sacrifice alone.

2.6 *Concealment and Unconcealment*

Calypso's name derives from *kalyptō*, "to cover, to conceal"; she detains the hero on the island the poem calls the "navel of the sea" (1.50). Athena pours mist over Ithaca so that Odysseus does not recognize his own land (13.189–193). At the Phaeacian feast Odysseus weeps behind his cloak, and "he escaped the notice of all the others as he shed tears" (ἔνθ' ἄλλους μὲν πάντας ἐλάνθανε δάκρυα λείβων, 8.93; repeated at 8.532)—all except Alcinous. Heidegger repeatedly cited this line to argue that Greek experiences concealment as a feature of being itself: not "he wept secretly" but "he remained concealed as the one weeping," so that truth (*alētheia*) is un-concealment.

Whatever the merits of Heidegger's philology, the *Odyssey* is structurally an aletheiology: a narrative of graduated unconcealment in which identity emerges from concealment (Calypso), passes through deliberate disguise (Athena's transformations), and arrives at disclosures staged with the precision of an economy.

The disclosures are calibrated by risk, trust and initiative. The involuntary recognitions are dangerous and must be contained: when Eurycleia's hand finds the scar, Odysseus seizes her by the throat and warns that if she speaks he will not spare her, nurse though she is, when he kills the other slave women of the house (19.479–490). The first breach in the economy of disclosure is sealed by a threat of death against an enslaved woman. The voluntary disclosures are gifts to those who have proved loyalty. The final disclosures are initiated by the other: Penelope sets the test, and Laertes demands a sign. Identity in the *Odyssey* is never simply asserted; it is conceded, extracted or verified, always within a relation.

2.7 *Against the Dialectic of Enlightenment*

The most influential modern critique of Odyssean reason is the first excursus of Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944; 1947), which reads Odysseus as the prototype of the bourgeois individual. Cunning, on their account, is the self's survival through self-denial: in calling himself Nobody, the subject saves itself by disowning its identity, so that the self it preserves is the abstract principle of self-preservation, which is also self-loss. The Sirens episode becomes an allegory of the

TABLE 1

The economy of disclosure

ADDRESSEE	PASSAGE	MODE OF DISCLOSURE	INITIATIVE
● The Phaeacians	9.19–20	Self-naming after days of hospitality	*Odysseus*
● Athena	13.221–440	Mutual unmasking of two deceivers	*Athena*
◐ Telemachus	16.172–219	Divine transformation, then bare assertion	*Athena, then Odysseus*
● Argos	17.290–327	Involuntary recognition through the disguise	*The dog*
● Eurycleia	19.386–475	Involuntary recognition by touch of the scar	*The nurse*
● Eumaeus and Philoetius	21.188–227	Scar shown as proof after a loyalty test	*Odysseus*
● The suitors	22.1–41	Revelation by violence	*Odysseus*
● Penelope	23.153–240	Challenge on the bed's construction	*Penelope*
● Laertes	24.315–348	Scar and the inventory of the orchard	*Laertes demands proof*

● Odysseus ● another ◐ both, in turn ▮ the twenty-four books, the passage's book marked

division of labor: the master, bound to the mast, enjoys a beauty he is powerless to act upon, while the rowers, their ears stopped with wax, labor without hearing. Sacrifice is internalized as renunciation.

The critique is unanswerable as a description of a tendency the poem dramatizes. Odysseus' survival repeatedly requires the instrumentalization of others—the scouts sent ahead, the companions bound and unbound, the twelve enslaved women whose execution Chapter 7 examines. On one point, however, the dialectic misreads the poem's architecture.

The sharpest instance is Scylla. Circe tells Odysseus that it is far better to mourn six companions than the whole crew (12.109–110), and he decides not to tell his men about the monster, lest in fear they stop rowing and huddle in the hold (12.223–225). Scylla seizes six of them from the ship; he calls it the most pitiful sight of all his wanderings (12.245–259). The economy of disclosure that shields the hero's identity also

governs what he withholds from his own men, and here it trades six lives for the ship without telling the six.

Horkheimer and Adorno treat Outis as self-annulment. The poem suggests something else: the self can become Nobody abroad because it is somebody elsewhere. It is held in trust on Ithaca by Penelope's memory and fidelity, by the bed's secret, by the scar a nurse will touch, by the dog that waits, by the orchard planted in a child's name. Anonymity is not the annihilation of identity but its temporary offloading into a sēmatic archive maintained by others.

No one can be Nobody who is not somewhere Somebody. Where the archive fails—where no one keeps the signs—Outis ceases to be a stratagem and becomes the permanent condition of the dispossessed: Eumaeus, the enslaved prince whom no one in his homeland can still recognize, is its figure (Chapter 7). The Outis principle presupposes the sēmatic self that Chapter 3 now analyzes.

The Sēmatic Archive

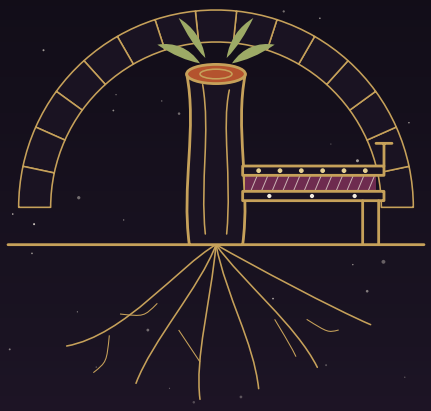
"No one can be Nobody who is not somewhere Somebody" (2.7)



FIGURE 2

The sēmatic archive

The self held in trust by others (2.7; Chapter 3). Each sign stands at the book in which it is read and is joined to those who read it; at the centre, the Nobody the hero can afford to be abroad.



CHAPTER THREE

The Sēmatic Self: Scar, Bed, Bow, Orchard

The Odyssean self is neither absent nor interior: it has an inside that speaks, but the warrant of its identity lies in signs—*sēmata*—distributed across bodies, artifacts, trees, animals and stories, and read by others. This chapter develops that claim against Snell and Auerbach, reads the recognition sequence of Books 16–24 as a protocol of authentication under conditions of perfect visual deception, and argues that recognition, in the poem's logic, is a capacity available only to mortals.

3.1 *Beyond Snell and Williams*

Bruno Snell (1946) observed that Homer lacks a word for the living body as a unity—*sōma* designates the corpse, while the living person appears as limbs (*guia*, *melea*) and skin (*chrōs*)—and lacks a unified seat of mental life, which is distributed among *psychē*, *thymos*, *noos* and *phrenes*. From these lacunae he inferred the absence of a unified self and of genuine decision, the gods supplying what the agent could not. Bernard Williams (1993) dismantled the inference. Homeric agents deliberate—Odysseus, isolated on the Iliadic battlefield, asks his own *thymos* why it debates these things (*Il.* 11.407)—and they intend, act, accept responsibility and feel a shame that internalizes the gaze of an imagined other.

The *Odyssey* contains the most famous inner dialogue in early Greek poetry. On the eve of the massacre, watching the slave women slip out to the suitors, Odysseus feels his heart "bark within him" like a bitch standing over her tender pups who growls at a stranger and is eager to fight (20.13–16). He strikes his breast and rebukes it: τέτλαθι δή, κραδίη· καὶ κύντερον ἄλλο ποτ' ἔτλης—"endure, my heart; you endured a more doglike thing once," when the Cyclops devoured his companions (20.18). Plato cites the verse twice: in the *Phaedo* (94d–e), as proof that the soul is no harmony of the body since it opposes the body's affections, and in the *Republic* (441b–c), as proof that the reasoning part of the soul rebukes the spirited part. The tripartite psychology finds its decisive witness in an Odyssean scene.

The image is worth pausing over. The heart is a dog, and the comparative κύντερον, "more doglike," is the poem's adjective for shamelessness: the belly too is κύντερον (7.216). The self is figured as a kennel of competing dogs—the barking heart within, the faithful hound Argos without. The poem thus possesses an interior; what it does not do is ground identity there. Who Odysseus is, for others and finally for himself, is settled by signs held outside him. This study calls that structure sēmatic selfhood.

The term exploits the semantic range of *sēma*: sign, token, portent, mark, and grave-marker. Telemachus is told that if he learns his father is dead he should heap up a *sēma* for him (1.291); Elpenor's shade asks for a *sēma* by the sea (11.75). The same word names the token by which a living man is identified and the mound by which a dead man is remembered. The self's signs are also its memorials, and that convergence will govern the poem's ending.

3.2 *Testimonial Identity: Telemachus' Doubt*

Asked by the disguised Athena whether he is truly Odysseus' son, Telemachus answers with an anti-cogito: μήτηρ μέν τέ μέ φησι τοῦ ἔμμεναι, αὐτὰρ ἐγώ γε / οὐκ οἶδ'· οὐ γάρ πώ τις ἐὸν γόνον αὐτὸς ἀνέγνω—"my mother says I am his; but I myself do not know, for no one yet has recognized his own begetting by himself" (1.215–216). Descartes' second *Meditation* grounds identity in a certainty that needs no witness; Telemachus' begins with a witness and ends in uncertainty. The verb is ἀνέγνω, the same verb of recognition that will crown Penelope's reading of the bed.

The Telemachy is accordingly an education in receiving identity from others. Nestor is astonished that the young man's words resemble his father's (3.123–125); Helen declares she has never seen such likeness (4.141–146); Menelaus notes the feet, the hands, the glance, the head and hair (4.148–150). The son is recognized by resemblance before the father is recognized by signs. In both cases the body is a text in which others read kinship, and the self cannot authenticate itself.

3.3 *The Scar: Auerbach Revisited*

The opening chapter of Erich Auerbach's *Mimesis* (1946) takes as its specimen the moment when Eurycleia, washing the beggar's feet, finds the scar. The narrative suspends the recognition for some seventy lines (19.393–466) to tell how the young Odysseus, visiting his grandfather Autolycus on Parnassus, was gored by a boar. For Auerbach the digression exemplifies a style that abhors vacancy: everything is foreground, uniformly illuminated, without background or suspense, in contrast to the story of Abraham's sacrifice, which is "fraught with background."

The digression admits a contrary reading. It is the poem's figure for background—not absent, but stored in the body and retrieved by touch. Eurycleia's hands recognize the scar before her eyes do (19.467–468). The scar is the body's archive: a record of initiation (the boar hunt as coming of age), of naming (Autolycus is the name-giver), and of the maternal line. Depth is not denied; it is externalized as inscription.

Aristotle supplies an unexpected confirmation. Praising the unity of the *Odyssey*'s plot, he observes that Homer did not include everything that befell Odysseus—for instance, his wounding on Parnassus (*Poetics* 1451a24–29). The event lies outside the unity of action and yet inside the poem as a sign. The *sēma* is a supplement that the plot excludes and that identity requires.

Paul Ricoeur (1990) distinguished *idem*-identity, the permanence of a mark through time, from *ipse*-identity, the self-constancy displayed in a kept promise. The scar is pure *idem*, and *idem* is forgeable: a scar can be imitated, a body disguised, a face replaced by a goddess's art. The poem therefore requires a sign of *ipse*.

3.4 *The Bed: Sēma, Secret, Homophrosynē*

Penelope supplies the test. She tells Eurycleia to move the well-made bed outside the bedchamber that Odysseus himself built (23.177–180). Odysseus flares: who has moved my bed? A great sign is built into it—μέγα σῆμα τέτυκται / ἐν λέχει ἀσκητῷ (23.188–189). He then narrates its making. A long-leaved olive grew within the court, thick as a pillar; he built the chamber around it with close-set stones, roofed it and hung its doors; he cut away the olive's crown, trimmed the trunk from the root, smoothed it with bronze, trued it to the line, made it a bedpost and bored it with an auger; from it he built the bed, inlaid it with gold, silver and ivory, and stretched across it thongs of oxhide dyed purple (23.190–201). "Thus I declare this sign to you," he ends, "but I do not know whether the bed still stands in place, woman, or whether some man has cut the olive at its base" (23.202–204).

Penelope's knees and heart give way, *σήματ' ἀναγνούσῃ, τά οἱ ἔμπεδα πέφραδ' Ὀδυσσεύς*—"having recognized the signs that Odysseus had declared to her as steadfast" (23.205–206). The verb *ἀναγιγνώσκω*, "to recognize," becomes in classical Greek the verb for reading. Penelope reads the bed.

The bed is a shared secret. Its construction is known only to the two of them and to a single maid, Actoris, given to Penelope by her father, who kept the doors of the chamber (23.226–229). Penelope had announced the existence of such signs before the test: "there are signs between us, hidden from others, that we two know" (*ἔστι γὰρ ἡμῖν / σήμαθ', ἃ δὴ καὶ νῶϊ κεκρυμμένα ἴδμεν ἀπ' ἄλλων*, 23.109–110). The test has the structure of a challenge–response protocol: a false premise is issued—the bed can be moved—and only the author of the bed can know that it cannot.

The authentication is mutual. Odysseus' knowledge proves who he is; the bed's integrity, which he cannot verify and fears for, proves who Penelope has been. His anger reveals *ipse*: what he fears in that instant is not the loss of his identity but the breach of a promise rooted in a living tree. The bed is the monument of fidelity, immovable unless someone has cut the olive at its root.

The poem names the cognitive form of this marriage. Speaking to Nausicaa, Odysseus wishes her a husband, a home and *homophrosynē*, for nothing is better than when man and woman keep house "like-minded in their thoughts" (*ὁμοφρονέοντε νοήμασιν*, 6.180–185). Daniel Wegner (1986) described couples as "transactive memory" systems that distribute remembering between partners; Clark and Chalmers (1998) argued that cognition extends into reliable external resources, such as the notebook of their Alzheimer's patient Otto. The bed is the notebook of a marriage: an external store of shared memory that is constitutive of the couple's cognitive identity. Bernard Stiegler's "tertiary retention" (1994), memory deposited in technical objects, describes the same structure; the Odyssean distinction is that this retention is rooted in a living tree.

The rootedness matters. The bed is not built from timber; it is built around a tree whose roots remain in the earth. Compare the expedition to the Cedar Forest in *Gilgamesh* (Tablet V): the heroes kill Humbaba, the forest's guardian, fell the cedars, and fashion from the tallest a monumental door for Enlil's temple at Nippur. Extractive heroism converts the living forest into a portal of power; Odyssean craft converts a living tree into a bed without uprooting it. Here are two archetypes of the relation between *technē* and *physis*.

Mircea Eliade's account of the *axis mundi*—the sacred center that joins the underworld, the earth and the sky (*Das Heilige und das Profane*, Hamburg: Rowohlt, 1957)—describes the structure exactly. The bedpost is a trunk whose roots still descend into the ground and whose crown once rose into the air, so that the marriage

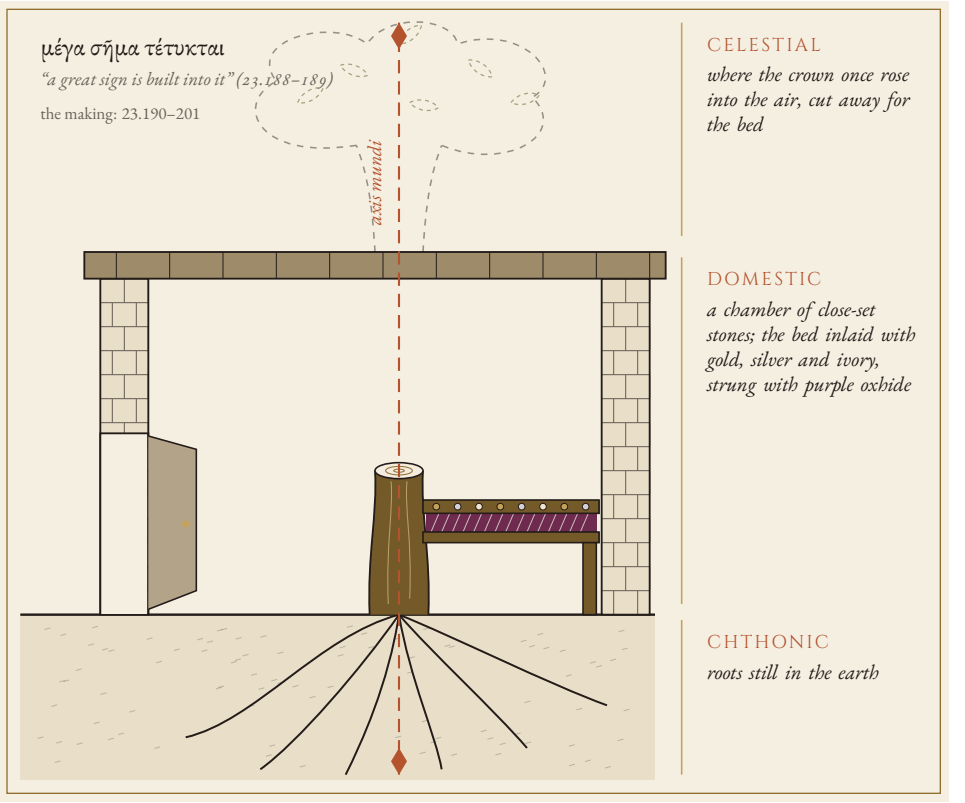


FIGURE 3

The bed as axis mundi

The bedpost is a living olive trimmed from the root, the chamber built around it with close-set stones (23.190–201): one vertical axis joining the chthonic, the domestic and the celestial (3.4).

bed stands on a vertical axis joining the chthonic, the domestic and the celestial. The symbolic center of the Odyssean home is a rooted tree made into a bed.

The olive, Athena's tree, structures the poem. A wild and a cultivated olive grow from one spot on the Phaeacian shore, and Odysseus sleeps between them (5.476–477). The stake that blinds the Cyclops is cut from the giant's own club of green olive wood (9.319–320). A long-leaved olive stands at the head of Phorcys' harbor on Ithaca, and beneath it goddess and hero plot the suitors' death (13.102; 13.372–373). The bedpost is an olive. The same tree serves as threshold, weapon, council and bed—an arboreal axis on which the poem's ethics of craft turns.

3.5 *Recognition as Authentication*

The second half of the *Odyssey* is an epic of identity verification under conditions of perfect visual deception. Athena withers Odysseus' skin, strips his hair and dims his eyes to make him an old beggar (13.429–438); restores and enhances him for Telemachus (16.172–176); disguises him again (16.454–459); and pours beauty over him before Penelope (23.156–163). Where a goddess can make anyone look like anyone, a face proves nothing. The poem therefore shifts authentication to non-visual channels and, in doing so, deploys every class of evidence a modern theory of verification would recognize.

TABLE 2

Authentication under perfect visual deception

	FACTOR	ODYSSEAN INSTANCE	VERIFIER	MODERN ANALOGUE
	Inherence: the body's history	The boar's scar (19.386–475; 21.217–221; 24.331–335)	Eurycleia; Eumaeus and Philoetius; Laertes	*Biometric verification*
	Knowledge: a shared secret	The bed's construction (23.183–204)	Penelope	*Challenge–response protocol*
	Knowledge: a shared history	The orchard's inventory (24.336–344)	Laertes	*Knowledge-based questions*
	Capability: an exclusive competence	Stringing and shooting the bow (21.404–423)	Suitors and household	*Proof of capability*
	Behavior and affect	Argos' recognition through the disguise (17.290–327)	The dog	*Behavioral signature*
	Testimony	The assertion to Telemachus (16.186–212)	Telemachus	*Attestation by a trusted party*

Penelope is the poem's theorist of this regime. She explains her long hesitation by her fear that some man would come and deceive her with words, "for many devise evil schemes for gain" (23.215–217), and she adduces Helen, who would never have lain with a foreigner had she known what would follow (23.218–224, lines some ancient critics suspected). Dan Sperber and his colleagues (2010) describe a suite of cognitive mechanisms of "epistemic vigilance" targeted at the risk of being misinformed; Penelope is its Homeric archetype.

Comparative evidence sharpens the point. In the Languedoc village of Artigat, around 1556, Arnaud du Tilh assumed the identity of the absent Martin Guerre

and lived for years with his wife, Bertrande de Rols; during the appeal of his trial at Toulouse in 1560 the true Martin Guerre returned, on a wooden leg, and the impostor was hanged. Natalie Zemon Davis (1983) argued that Bertrande may knowingly have accepted the impostor in an "invented marriage." Homeric scholarship has its exact analogue in the hypothesis that Penelope recognizes Odysseus before the formal recognition, in Book 19 (Harsh 1950; Winkler 1990), against which Katz (1991) insisted on the poem's deliberate indeterminacy. Both cases pose the same question: does recognition discover an identity or ratify a choice? The bed test answers that it does both: an act of will that produces knowledge.

Indian epic offers parallels and an inversion. In the *Mahābhārata*'s story of Nala and Damayantī, Nala, transformed by the serpent Karkoṭaka into the misshapen charioteer Bāhuka, is recognized by his wife through his skills—his mastery of horses, his cooking—and she draws him back by announcing a sham second *svayaṃvara*, a bride's self-choice. The structure is that of Penelope's contest of the bow: the wife stages a remarriage in order to summon the disguised husband. The *Rāmāyaṇa*'s *agniparīkṣā*, by contrast, has Rāma demand that Sītā prove her purity by fire. The woman is tested by the man. The *Odyssey* does not lack its own suspicion of wives—Agamemnon's shade counsels Odysseus to trust no woman (11.441–456)—but the test that closes its recognition is administered by the woman to the man.

When Telemachus refuses to believe, Odysseus asserts his uniqueness: οὐ μὲν γάρ τοι ἔτ' ἄλλος ἐλεύσεται ἐνθάδ' Ὀδυσσεύς, / ἀλλ' ὅδ' ἐγὼ τοιόσδε—"no other Odysseus will ever come here; I am he, such as I am" (16.204–205). The claim of numerical uniqueness against the possibility of copies is one that speculative fiction would put under pressure: Lem's *Solaris*, with its visitors fashioned from memory; Egan's *Permutation City*, with its proliferating Copies; and the synthetic impersonations of the present. When visual identity becomes infinitely reproducible, verification must revert to what the *Odyssey* already relies on: embodied history, shared secrets, demonstrated capability, and the testimony of those who have lived through the same time.

3.6 *Argos and the Golden Dogs: Recognition as a Mortal Capacity*

At the door of Alcinous' palace stand dogs of gold and silver, which Hephaestus fashioned with cunning skill to guard the house, ἀθανάτους ὄντας καὶ ἀγήρως ἤματα πάντα—"being deathless and ageless all their days" (7.91–94). The formula is the one in which Calypso framed her offer (5.136; cf. 7.257; 23.336). The machine-dogs possess what Odysseus refuses.

At the gate of his own house lies Argos (17.290–327). Raised by Odysseus before Troy and once swift in the hunt, he lies neglected on a heap of dung, full of ticks. Rec-

ognizing his master through the disguise, he wags his tail and drops his ears, but lacks the strength to come near. Odysseus wipes away a tear unseen by Eumaeus (17.304–305), and "the fate of black death seized Argos as soon as he had seen Odysseus in the twentieth year" (17.326–327).

The immortal dogs guard; the mortal dog recognizes. The golden dogs cannot recognize, because nothing has happened to them: they have no history to share with anyone. Argos recognizes because he has aged through the same twenty years; his decrepitude measures the absence, and his recognition is the reading of a self by a being who carries the same elapsed time. Recognition, the poem implies, is a mortal capacity: to recognize is to bear in one's own body the time of the other's absence.

On Ogygia, among the deathless, Odysseus could have been loved, but he could not have been recognized; there would have been no one in whom his time was inscribed. Vernant (1982) argued that Calypso's immortality would have been an immortality of anonymity, a "hiding" of the hero from *kleos*. The contrast of the dogs extends that argument: deathlessness forfeits not only fame but the very condition of being known.

Two modern fictions confirm the intuition from opposite directions. Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) imagines artificial beings who acquire minds only through years of shared experience that cannot be compressed or skipped: experience is the irreplaceable medium of mutual recognition. Borges's "El inmortal" (1947) has its narrator name a mute troglodyte Argos, after Odysseus' dog, and discover that he is Homer, an immortal who has nearly forgotten his own poem. The dog's name, given to the deathless poet, marks the irony exactly: among immortals no one recognizes anyone.

3.7 *The Uncanny Homeland and the Levinasian Objection*

Odysseus wakes on Ithaca and does not recognize it, because Athena has poured mist around him (13.187–193). He laments in the formula he used on the Phaeacian shore and before the land of the Cyclopes: "Alas, to the land of what mortals have I come now? Are they violent and savage and unjust, or hospitable to strangers, with a god-fearing mind?" (13.200–202 = 6.119–121; cf. 9.175–176). Home is approached with the ethnographer's question. Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) defined the uncanny as the once-familiar become strange, the word *heimlich* turning into its own opposite. The Odyssean homeland is the paradigm of that reversal: home returns as a foreign land.

Emmanuel Levinas opposed to the myth of Ulysses returning to Ithaca the story of Abraham, who leaves his fatherland forever for an unknown land (Levinas 1963).

Western philosophy, on this view, is an Odyssey of the Same that reduces every Other to itself, and Hegel's *Phenomenology* is its itinerary of spirit returning to itself enriched.

The sēmatic reading answers on three counts. First, home is not simply possessed; it must be re-read, and the returner begins as a stranger to it. Second, the self is returned to itself by the other: Penelope authenticates Odysseus, not the reverse, and the father is recognized only after the son, the nurse, the dog and the servants have read him. Third, the prophecy of Teiresias mandates a final journey toward people who do not know the sea—absolute strangers—to whom the voyager must surrender the meaning of his instrument.

The nostic is therefore not the Same returning to itself. It is a self that can return only through the recognition of another, and that ends by entrusting its last sign to strangers who will misread it. The Abrahamic exodus is not opposed to the Odyssean return; it is folded into its end.



CHAPTER FOUR

Elected Finitude: Calypso, Gilgamesh, and the Refusal of the Deathless

The decisive philosophical act of the *Odyssey* is a refusal: offered deathlessness and agelessness by a goddess whose superiority he concedes, Odysseus chooses a mortal wife, a foretold suffering and an unknown death. This chapter reads the refusal closely, sets it against *Gilgamesh* and against the poem's own economy of immortal exceptions, follows its philosophical reception from Plato to Nussbaum, and tests it against the speculative fictions that have tried to retract it.

4.1 *Ogygia: The Navel and the Veil*

Ogygia is the "navel of the sea" (1.50), and its mistress is the daughter of Atlas, who knows the depths of every sea and holds the tall pillars that keep earth and sky apart (1.52–54). Her name derives from *kalyptō*, "to cover, to conceal." Hermes, arriving with Zeus' command, finds a great cave fragrant with burning cedar and citron-wood; the goddess sings within as she plies her loom with a golden shuttle (5.61–62). Around the cave grow alder, poplar and cypress; birds nest there; a vine heavy with grapes trails over the entrance; four springs run in parallel; meadows of violet and parsley bloom, so that even an immortal coming there would gaze and rejoice in his heart (5.63–74). Ogygia is the *locus amoenus* in perfected form: aesthetic plenitude without need.

The book that contains the offer of immortality opens with a deliberate frame: Ἠὼς δ' ἐκ λεχέων παρ' ἀγαυοῦ Τιθωνοῖο / ὄρνυθ'—"Dawn rose from her bed beside lordly Tithonus" (5.1–2). The formula also opens *Iliad* 11, but here it places at the threshold of Calypso's offer the archetype of its failure. Tithonus is the mortal lover for whom Dawn obtained deathlessness but forgot to ask for youth, so that he shrivels eternally beside her (*Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* 218–238). The poem signals at once that Calypso's offer is not the Tithonian one. She promises both: ἀθάνατον καὶ ἀγήρων, deathless and ageless (5.136). What Odysseus refuses is not a defective immortality but a perfect one.

Ogygia, moreover, has a loom. Calypso weaves, as Circe weaves (10.221–223) and as Penelope weaves. Only one of the three unweaves. The goddesses' textiles accumulate in a time that cannot be reversed because it cannot be lost; only the mortal weaver, whose time is finite, makes time reversible by night. Chapter 8 returns to the distinction.

4.2 *The Offer and the Answer*

The poem's first image of its hero is an image of attrition. By day Odysseus sits on the shore weeping, gazing at the barren sea, and κατείβετο δὲ γλυκὺς αἰὼν / νόστον ὀδυρομένῳ—"his sweet life was flowing away as he mourned for his return" (5.152–153); by night he sleeps beside her, "unwilling beside the willing" (παρ' οὐκ ἐθέλων ἐθελούσῃ, 5.155). R. B. Onians (1951) showed that *aiōn* designates the life-fluid, the moisture of vitality, before it means a span of time. The hero's life drains from him as liquid; immortality would arrest the flow. His suffering is precisely the leakage of finite life into longing.

Calypso's complaint to Hermes rehearses the divine monopoly on deathlessness. The gods begrudge goddesses who openly take mortal lovers: Artemis killed Orion, beloved of Dawn; Zeus struck down Iasion, beloved of Demeter. She saved Odysseus when his ship was shattered, "and fed him and loved him, and said that I would make him deathless and ageless all his days" (5.118–136). When she announces his release, he demands the great oath by the Styx before he will believe her (5.173–179). Divine gifts are presumed to be traps until sworn otherwise.

The final exchange (5.203–224) is the philosophical center of the poem. Calypso argues: if you knew how many sorrows you are fated to fill up before reaching your land, you would stay here with me, keep this house and be deathless, though you long to see your wife, for whom you yearn every day; and I claim to be not inferior to her in form or stature, since mortal women cannot rival immortals in beauty (5.206–213). Odysseus answers:

πότνα θεά, μή μοι τόδε χώεο· οἶδα καὶ αὐτὸς
πάντα μάλ', οὕνεκα σεῖο περίφρων Πηνελόπεια
εἶδος ἀκιδνοτέρη μέγεθός τ' εἰσάντα ἰδέσθαι·
ἡ μὲν γὰρ βροτός ἐστι, σὺ δ' ἀθάνατος καὶ ἀγήρως.
ἀλλὰ καὶ ὥς ἐθέλω καὶ ἐέλδομαι ἤματα πάντα
οἴκαδέ τ' ἐλθέμεναι καὶ νόστιμον ἦμαρ ἰδέσθαι.

(5.215–220)

"Lady goddess, do not be angry with me for this. I know it all myself: that prudent Penelope is lesser than you to look upon in form and stature, for she is mortal, and you are deathless and ageless. But even so I wish and long every day to go home and see the day of my return." If some god shatters him on the wine-dark sea, he adds, he will endure it, having in his breast a heart that endures sorrows; he has suffered much already, "let this too be added" (5.221–224).

Five features of the answer deserve emphasis. First, Odysseus grants every premise of Calypso's argument—her superior form, her deathlessness, her agelessness. Second, he does not argue against immortality: he adduces neither Tithonus, nor tedium, nor the meaninglessness of endless life. Third, the pivot is two words, ἀλλὰ καὶ ὥς, "but even so." The choice is not deduced from premises; it is a preference that holds against acknowledged superiority, the particular preferred to the perfect.

Fourth, the object of preference is not only Penelope but "to go home and see the day of return" (νόστιμον ἦμαρ): a day, an event in time. He chooses a life in time, not merely a person. Fifth, he chooses a suffering foreknown: Calypso has warned him of sorrows to come, and he answers with τλήσομαι, "I will endure." The epithet *polytlas*, "much-enduring," becomes the name of a philosophical stance: endurance as the virtue that accepts finitude in advance. He repeats the choice to Arete—Calypso promised to make him deathless and ageless, "but she never persuaded the heart in my breast" (7.256–258)—to the Phaeacians (9.29–36), and to Penelope (23.333–337).

Jean-Pierre Vernant's "The Refusal of Odysseus" (1982) read the choice as a refusal of an immortality of concealment: to stay with the goddess whose name means "she who hides" would be to vanish from the human world and from *kleos*. Martha Nussbaum's "Transcending Humanity" (1990) made the same scene the paradigm of what she called internal transcendence—striving for excellence within the bounds of a human life—against the external transcendence that seeks to leave humanity behind. The values that make a human life worth living, she argued, among them courage, love, friendship and justice, are constituted by vulnerability and limit and would not survive translation into divine existence.

Bernard Williams's "The Makropulos Case" (1973) took its occasion from Karel Čapek's play *Věc Makropulos* (1922), whose heroine, kept alive for more than three centuries by her father's elixir, finally refuses to renew it. Williams argued that an endless life would exhaust the categorical desires that give us reason to go on, collapsing either into tedium or into a change of character amounting to the loss of the self. Fischer (1994) objected that repeatable pleasures could sustain an immortal life. The *Odyssey*'s position is subtler than either: Odysseus does not refuse because immortality would be boring; he refuses because it would sever him from the particular objects of his love and from the time in which they exist.

4.3 *The Anti-Gilgamesh*

After the death of Enkidu, Gilgamesh, terrified of dying, sets out to find Utnapishtim, the survivor of the Flood to whom the gods granted everlasting life. In the Old Babylonian version, Siduri, the ale-wife at the sea's edge, counsels him: since the gods allotted death to mankind and kept life in their own hands, he should fill his belly, make merry day and night, wear clean garments, wash his head and bathe, cherish the little one who holds his hand, and let his wife delight in his embrace, for such is the lot of man. This is, almost point for point, the nostic program: food, festivity, cleanliness, child, spouse.

Gilgamesh rejects the counsel and crosses the Waters of Death. Utnapishtim challenges him to stay awake for six days and seven nights; he falls asleep at once, and loaves baked each day, in successive stages of decay, prove the days he slept. Given a plant of rejuvenation, he loses it to a snake while bathing in a pool. He returns to Uruk and shows the boatman Urshanabi its walls, its brickwork and its gardens (SB XI.323–328), in lines that repeat the prologue (I.18–23): the city built by human hands is all the permanence a mortal may have.

The antithesis with the *Odyssey* is exact. Gilgamesh seeks immortality and fails; Odysseus is offered it and refuses. Gilgamesh ends in nostic resignation before the walls of human work; Odysseus begins from nostic affirmation. Siduri's counsel, refused by the Mesopotamian hero, is enacted by the Greek one. In this precise sense the *Odyssey* is an anti-*Gilgamesh*.

The two epics share a motif that clarifies the difference: the hero's catastrophic sleep. Gilgamesh's sleep loses immortality. Odysseus' sleep twice loses his homecoming: he falls asleep with Ithaca in sight, and the companions open the bag of winds (10.31–55); he falls asleep on Thrinacia, and the companions slaughter the cattle of the Sun (12.338–373). His last sleep is the Phaeacian passage: νήγρετος, ἥδιστος, θανάτῳ ἄγχιστα ἐοικώς—"unwaking, sweetest, most like death" (13.80). In *Gilgamesh*, sleep is the rehearsal of death that disqualifies a man from immortality. In the *Odyssey*, sleep is the threshold

through which mortality is re-entered: the hero arrives home asleep, carried across the sea by ensouled ships, as if reborn into his own finitude.

Two further scenes complete the pattern, and both concern what remains of a man at the edge of death. When the bag of winds is opened and Ithaca vanishes from sight, Odysseus wakes and deliberates whether to fall from the ship and perish in the sea, or to endure in silence and remain among the living: ἀλλ' ἔτλην καὶ ἔμεινα, "but I endured and stayed," and he lay in the ship with his head covered (καλυψάμενος, 10.49–54). The verb of covering is Calypso's. Elected finitude is therefore a double refusal: it declines deathlessness on Ogygia and declines death in the sea off Aeolia. Both choices affirm a bounded life against an exit from it—upward into the time of the gods, or downward out of time altogether—and both are acts of the same virtue, the endurance that names him *polytlas*.

The second scene is the arrival at Scheria. Naked and spent, Odysseus crawls between a wild and a cultivated olive grown from one spot and covers himself with fallen leaves, as a man on a remote farm without neighbors hides a burning brand in black ashes, σπέρμα πυρὸς σώζων, "saving the seed of fire," so that he need not kindle it from elsewhere (5.476–491). The simile reduces the hero to the smallest unit of human culture, a preserved ember, at the threshold between the sea and the human world. It is the poem's image of the finite self at its minimum: not a soul that escapes the body, but a spark kept alive under cover until it can be carried home. In the Hesiodic background fire is what Prometheus stole for mortals (*Theog.* 565–569; *Op.* 50–52), and Bernard Stiegler (1994) made the Promethean myth the emblem of a humanity constituted by its technical supplements; the Odyssean ember is that supplement in its last and most fragile form.

4.4 *The Poem's Economy of Exceptions*

The poem maintains a jealous divine monopoly on deathlessness and records its exceptions with taxonomic care. Menelaus will not die in Argos but will be sent to the Elysian plain, where life is easiest for men, with no snow or storm, only the breezes of Zephyr—not for any merit, but "because you have Helen and are son-in-law of Zeus" (4.561–569). Immortality by marriage into the divine family.

In Hades Odysseus sees the phantom (*eidōlon*) of Heracles, "but he himself" feasts among the immortal gods with Hebe as his wife (11.601–604)—a split self, shade below and self above, in lines ancient critics suspected and Plotinus later used as an image of the soul's division (*Enneads* 1.1.12; 4.3.27). Castor and Polydeuces lie beneath the grain-giving earth yet alive, living on alternate days and dead on alternate days, with honor equal to the gods' (11.298–304): immortality shared and rationed. Ino Leu-

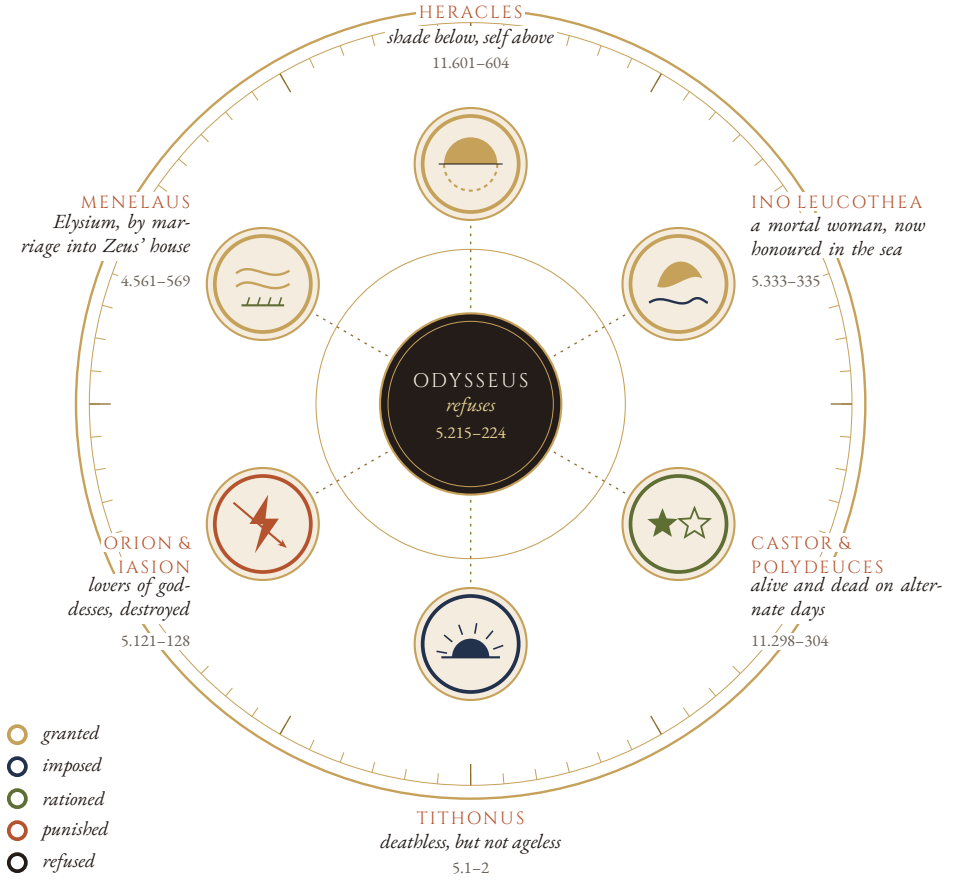


FIGURE 4

The poem's economy of exceptions

Each exception to the divine monopoly on deathlessness is granted, imposed, rationed or punished (4.4). At the centre, the only voluntary renunciation.

cothea, once a mortal woman of human speech, now holds honor among the gods in the sea (5.333–335), and it is her veil that saves Odysseus from drowning. Orion and Iasion, mortal lovers of goddesses, are destroyed (5.121–128). Tithonus frames the whole (5.1).

Within this field, every exception is granted, imposed, rationed or punished. Odysseus' is the only voluntary renunciation of deathlessness by a mortal in the poem.

4.5 *The Nekyia's Anthropology of Death*

Among the shades Odysseus meets his mother, Anticleia, whose death he did not know. She died, she tells him, not by sickness and not by Artemis' gentle arrows: ἀλλά με σός τε πόθος σά τε μήδεα, φαίδιμ' Ὀδυσσεῦ, / σή τ' ἀγανοφροσύνη μελιηδέα θυμὸν ἀπηύρα—"it was longing for you, and for your counsels, shining Odysseus, and for your gentleness, that took my honey-sweet life away" (11.202–203). It is the first death by nostalgia in Western literature.

Three times he tries to embrace her, and three times she flits from his hands like a shadow or a dream (11.204–208). She explains that this is the law of mortals when they die: the sinews no longer hold the flesh and bones, fire destroys them, and the *psychē* flits away like a dream (ψυχὴ δ' ἠΰτ' ὄνειρος ἀποπταμένη πεπότηται, 11.218–222). The first Greek metaphysics of death is spoken by a mother to her son, and its content is the irrecoverability of the embrace.

Achilles completes the anthropology. When Odysseus flatters his shade that he rules among the dead, Achilles answers:

> βουλοίμην κ' ἐπάρουρος ἐὼν θητευέμεν ἄλλῳ, 489
> ἀνδρὶ παρ' ἀκλήρῳ, ᾧ μὴ βίοτος πολὺς εἴη, 490
> ἢ πᾶσιν νεκύεσσι καταφθιμένοισιν ἀνάσσειν. 491
>
> (11.489–491)

"I would rather be bound to the soil as a hired laborer for another, a man without land and with little livelihood, than be lord over all the perished dead." The hero who in the *Iliad* chose imperishable fame over return retracts the choice in death. The lowest embodied life outranks the highest disembodied existence.

Plato's reception of these lines is the hinge of the gnostic Odyssey. In *Republic* 3 (386c) Socrates strikes them from the education of the guardians, because they would make young men fear death. In *Republic* 7 (516d) he quotes the same words to describe the freed prisoner who, having seen the sun, would rather "be a serf on the land to another, a man without lot" than return to the honors of the cave. Plato thereby inverts the Homeric hierarchy. Homer's line affirms embodied life against the shadows of Hades; Plato's reuse makes embodied life itself the realm of shadows. The anti-gnostic verse par excellence becomes the motto of philosophical ascent. Chapter 9 traces the consequences.

Plato's last word on Odysseus is subtler still. In the Myth of Er, the soul of Odysseus draws the last lot; remembering its former toils and recovered from the love of honor, it goes about for a long time seeking the life of a private man who minds his own business, finds it lying neglected, and chooses it gladly, saying it would have done the same

had it drawn the first lot (*Republic* 10.620c–d). The wisest soul chooses obscurity: the Outis principle completed in eschatology. Epicurus' maxim *lathe biōsas*, "live unnoticed" (fr. 551 Usener), generalizes it, and Lucretius gives Nature a speech rebuking the man who clamors for more life when he has had his fill (3.931–977).

4.6 *Speculative Trials of the Choice*

The refusal of Calypso is the founding choice of humanism, and speculative fiction has repeatedly tried to retract it. The first retraction is ancient. The *Telegony*, as summarized by Proclus, ends with Circe making Penelope and Telemachus immortal: the earliest sequel to the poem bestows deathlessness on the very family for whose sake it was refused.

Lucian's *True History* (second century CE) stages the retraction as comedy. On the Isle of the Blessed, Odysseus secretly entrusts the narrator with a letter for Calypso (2.29). Delivered on Ogygia (2.35), it tells her that after leaving her he was shipwrecked, conveyed home by the Phaeacians, killed the suitors, was later killed by Telegonus, and now, among the blessed, regrets having abandoned his life with her and the immortality she offered, and will escape to her at the first opportunity. Calypso weeps over it. The text often called the first work of science fiction thus stages the retraction of the founding choice of humanism. Lucian's joke is philosophically exact: once the afterlife is imagined as a continuation of pleasure, the Odyssean refusal loses its ground. The refusal presupposes the Homeric Hades of Achilles' lament.

Swift's Struldbruggs (*Gulliver's Travels* 3.10) show why Calypso's qualification matters. Told that some children in Luggnagg are born immortal, Gulliver rhapsodizes about the wisdom he would accumulate; he then learns that they age without end, are declared legally dead at eighty, lose memory and language, and become objects of universal horror. Tithonus becomes a social institution, and the apotheotic fantasy is satirized.

Tennyson split the Homeric synthesis into a diptych. "Ulysses" (1842) refuses rest beside a still hearth, "match'd with an aged wife," and resolves "to sail beyond the sunset"; "Tithonus" (1860) begs Dawn to release him from the fact that "me only cruel immortality / Consumes." Homer joins the refusal of immortality to the return home; Tennyson disjoins them into Faustian departure and Tithonian lament.

Borges's "El inmortal" (1947) is an *argumentum ad Calypso*. Its narrator, a Roman tribune, drinks from a river that confers immortality and finds the City of the Immortals, an architecture without purpose, and its inhabitants, troglodytes indifferent to everything—among them the one he names Argos, who proves to be Homer. Among immortals, every act will eventually be performed and every word said, so that no act

has weight. The narrator spends centuries seeking the river that will take immortality away; when a thorn finally draws blood from his hand, he rejoices to be mortal again. Mortality makes acts irreversible, and irreversibility makes them precious.

Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994) dissolves personal continuity into uploaded Copies and an infinitely instantiable "Dust," the limit case in which the sēmatic self is undone by reproducibility. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) imagines a linguist who acquires foreknowledge and nonetheless chooses to conceive a daughter whose early death she knows in advance. Odysseus too hears his future from Teiresias, including the manner of his death (11.100–137), and goes home anyway: foreknowledge does not abolish choice but transforms it into assent.

Madeline Miller's *Circe* (2018) completes the Odyssean logic from the divine side: after millennia of deathless solitude, the goddess uses her own craft to make herself mortal and live a human life. If value requires limit, a goddess who loves must also elect finitude.

Philosophical non-fiction has reopened the question in technological terms. Nick Bostrom's "Fable of the Dragon-Tyrant" (2005) presents death as a tyrant to be slain and senescence as a problem to be solved. Martin Hägglund's *This Life* (2019) argues the opposite: finitude is the condition of care, because only a being that can lose what it loves has reason to devote its time to anything. Heidegger's being-toward-death (*Being and Time* §§46–53) describes authenticity as a running-ahead toward one's own end; the Odyssean stance is less heroic and more domestic—the choosing of a life whose end is known. Nietzsche's demon asks whether one would will this life again innumerable times (*The Gay Science* 341); Plato's Odysseus, choosing the same obscure life whichever lot he drew, had already answered.

4.7 *Value as a Function of the Limit*

Elected finitude is neither Siduri's resignation, which counsels acceptance of what cannot be changed, nor Achilles' heroic death-seeking, which trades life for fame, nor the *Phaedo*'s contempt for the body, which makes philosophy a practice of dying. It is the affirmation, against a real alternative, of a bounded life as the medium of recognition, love and fame. This study formulates the principle as the axiological thesis of the limit: in the *Odyssey*, a good is recognizable as a good only within a horizon of possible loss.

The poem demonstrates the thesis by contrast. When Demodocus sings of Ares and Aphrodite caught in Hephaestus' net, the gods break into "unquenchable laughter" (ἄσβεστος ... γέλως, 8.326). Adultery, which in the human plot destroys the house of Agamemnon, is among the deathless a farce. Divine life cannot be tragic, because nothing in it can be lost forever. Nussbaum's point follows: courage, generosity and fi-

delity presuppose vulnerability. Odysseus chooses the world in which fidelity can mean something because infidelity can destroy. The refusal of Calypso is not anti-divine but pro-meaning, and that is the full philosophical content of ἀλλὰ καὶ ὥς: even so.



CHAPTER FIVE

Between Beast and God: Cosmology, Physis, and the Fractured Theodicy

The *Odyssey* defines the human as a middle position—between the automatic existence of gods and golden-age peoples and the raw existence of beasts—and marks that position by bread, sacrifice, labor and a knowledge of nature first given as an antidote to bestial metamorphosis. Its gods, meanwhile, do not form a moral system: three incommensurable regimes of divine causation coexist, adjudicated rather than unified by Zeus. This chapter maps the cosmology, reads the first appearance of *physis*, reconstructs the fractured theodicy, and draws out the poem's philosophy of the belly.

5.1 *The Human Middle*

Pierre Vidal-Naquet's essay on land and sacrifice in the *Odyssey* (1970) established that the poem's human world is defined by agriculture—men are "bread-eaters" (σιτοφάγοι), "grain-consuming" (ἀλφησταί)—and by sacrifice, which together fix the human place between gods and beasts. The wanderings occur in a world where these markers are absent or perverted. The Lotus-eaters live on a flower; the Cyclopes neither plow nor sacrifice and eat men; the Laestrygonians spear men like fish; on Circe's island men become swine. On Thrinacia the starving companions sacrifice the forbidden cattle

using oak leaves in place of barley and water in place of wine (12.356–363): a sacrifice whose every element confesses its displacement. The return to Ithaca is a return to the world of bread and correct sacrifice.

Greek political philosophy formalized the poem's map. Aristotle defines the human as by nature a political animal and declares that one who is without a city by nature is either a beast or a god (θηρίον ἢ θεός, *Politics* 1253a27–29), citing in the same passage the Iliadic curse on the man who is "clanless, lawless, hearthless" (*Il.* 9.63). A page earlier, describing the household rule that preceded the polis, he quotes the *Odyssey*'s account of the Cyclopes: "each one gives law to his children and wives" (θεμιστεύει δὲ ἕκαστος / παίδων ἠδ' ἀλόχων, 9.114–115; *Politics* 1252b22–23). Plato's *Laws* (680b–c) cites the same lines to describe the earliest form of rule. The Cyclopes became, in Greek theory, the paradigm of the pre-political.

The poem thus organizes its cosmos along a vertical axis. Above stand beings whose existence is deathless, effortless and automatic. Below stand beings who eat raw and live without law. Between them stands the human, defined by labor, sacrifice, mortality and speech in assembly. Nostos is movement along the horizontal axis toward home and, simultaneously, convergence along the vertical axis toward the human middle.

5.2 *The Golden-Age Twins*

The poem places beyond the human world two peoples who embody, between them, the features of Hesiod's golden age. The Cyclopes are "overbearing and lawless"; trusting in the immortal gods, they neither plant nor plow, yet wheat, barley and vines grow for them unsown; they have no assemblies for counsel and no ordinances, but live in hollow caves on mountain peaks, each giving law to his children and wives, caring nothing for one another (9.106–115). They have no ships and no shipwrights (9.125–129), and they boast that they care nothing for Zeus, being stronger than the gods (9.275–278).

The Phaeacians once lived beside them, in spacious Hypereia, until the Cyclopes, who were stronger, harmed them; their king Nausithous led them away to Scheria, walled a city, built houses and temples, and divided the plowland (6.4–10). They live "far off, at the edge of the sea," where no hostile mortal comes (6.201–205). The gods appear to them openly at their sacrifices and sit beside them at feasts, and Alcinous explains why: "we are near to them, as are the Cyclopes and the wild tribes of the Giants" (7.201–206). Both peoples descend from Poseidon—Polyphemus is his son (1.68–73), and so is Nausithous, the Phaeacian founder (7.56–62). The poem thus constructs twin golden-age societies, one anti-hospitable and one hyper-hospitable, both Poseidonian, both near the gods.



FIGURE 5

The human middle

The poem's vertical axis, after Vidal-Naquet and Aristotle's "beast or god" (5.1). Nostos moves along the horizontal toward home and, at once, inward to the middle band.

The pairing amounts to a critique of the golden age. Hesiod's earth bore fruit "of itself" (αὐτομάτη, *Op.* 117–118); the *Odyssey* asks what kind of society self-bearing abundance produces, and gives two answers—savagery in the one case, a sequestered and fragile utopia in the other. Neither is a human home.

One passage in the Cyclops episode adds a third perspective, the colonist's. Offshore lies an island full of wild goats, unvisited by hunters, unplowed and unsown. Odysseus appraises it like a prospector: it would bear every crop in season; it has soft, well-watered meadows by the shore, deep soil for plowing, a harbor needing no mooring; only the Cyclopes' lack of ships prevents them from making it a well-settled place (9.116–141). Irad Malkin (1998) and Carol Dougherty (2001) read the passage as a colonial prospectus embedded in myth. It is also the seed of the Faustian vector traced in Chapter 9: the gaze that sees in an "empty" land only cultivation deferred.

5.3 *Circe and the Mind in the Animal*

Circe mixes into a potion of cheese, barley and honey "baneful drugs, so that they might utterly forget their homeland" (ἵνα πάγχυ λαθοίατο πατρίδος αἴης, 10.236), strikes the companions with her wand and pens them in a sty. They have the heads, voices, bristles and bodies of swine—αὐτὰρ νοῦς ἦν ἔμπεδος ὡς τὸ πάρος περ, "but their mind was steadfast as before" (10.240). It is the first literary dissociation of mind from bodily form. The drug is aimed at the oblivion of the homeland, as the lotus was; the animal form is its vehicle; and yet the mind persists.

The scene is a thought experiment in personal identity. Locke would ask whether a prince's consciousness transferred into a cobbler's body makes the cobbler the prince (*Essay* 2.27.15). Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915) imagines the Circean condition without Hermes: Gregor Samsa's mind persists in an insect's body while his family progressively ceases to recognize him. Restored by Circe, the companions become younger, taller and handsomer than before, and weep so loudly that the goddess herself pities them (10.395–399).

Plutarch's dialogue *Gryllus* (*Bruta animalia ratione uti*) gives the sty a voice. Odysseus asks Circe to restore the Greeks among her beasts; she lets him put the question to one of them, the pig Gryllus, who refuses rehumanization and argues that animals surpass humans in courage, temperance and natural intelligence uncorrupted by convention. It is the first sustained philosophical defense of animal life against the humanist presumption, and it is set in the Odyssean sty. Boethius drew the opposite moral: Circe's drugs change bodies but not minds, whereas the true poisons are the vices that transform the self within while the body remains (*Consolation of Philosophy* 4, metrum 3). Montaigne's defense of animal reason in the *Apologie de Raymond Sebond* and Derrida's *L'animal que donc je suis* (2006) extend the dispute.

The *Odyssey* holds the two positions in tension. It values the human form as the condition of return—the moly preserves it—but it allows the animal-bodied mind a persistence of its own and, in Argos, gives a beast the poem's most perfect act of recognition.

5.4 *Physis: The First Nature*

Hermes, meeting Odysseus on the path to Circe's house, gives him the counter-drug:

> ὣς ἄρα φωνήσας πόρε φάρμακον ἀργεϊφόντης 302
> ἐκ γαίης ἐρύσας, καί μοι φύσιν αὐτοῦ ἔδειξε. 303
>
> (10.302–303)

"So speaking, the Slayer of Argus gave me the drug, drawing it from the earth, and showed me its nature." It was black at the root and its flower was like milk; the gods call it moly; it is hard for mortal men to dig, but the gods can do all things (10.304–306). This is the only occurrence of φύσις in the Homeric corpus.

Pierre Hadot (2004) showed that *physis* first designates a process—the growth (*phuō*) by which a thing comes to be what it is—and only later Nature as a totality, and he traced the long history of Heraclitus' dictum that *physis* loves to hide (φύσις κρύπτεσθαι φιλεῖ, DK B123). The first *physis* in Greek already has that structure. It is revealed by a god; it is the nature of a plant; it is defined by the contrast of a black root and a white flower—the hidden and the manifest, the underground and the luminous; it is known through the difficulty of digging, knowledge as labor that only gods perform effortlessly; and it serves as a counter-*pharmakon* against a drug that turns humans into beasts.

Nature thus enters Western discourse as the knowledge that keeps the human human. The Presocratic inquiry "concerning nature" inherits, unknowingly, a scene in which *physis* is the antidote to metamorphosis. The same root returns at the poem's climax in Phemius' plea that a god "made songs grow" (ἐνέφυσεν) in his mind (22.348): *physis* grows herbs and it grows songs.

5.5 *Theodicy in Three Registers*

The poem opens with a theodicy spoken by Zeus himself:

ὢ πόποι, οἷον δή νυ θεοὺς βροτοὶ αἰτιόωνται. 32
ἐξ ἡμέων γάρ φασι κάκ' ἔμμεναι· οἱ δὲ καὶ αὐτοὶ 33
σφῇσιν ἀτασθαλίῃσιν ὑπὲρ μόρον ἄλγε' ἔχουσιν. 34

(1.32–34)

"Look how mortals blame the gods! They say their evils come from us, but they themselves, through their own recklessness, have sorrows beyond their portion." The example is Aegisthus, warned by Hermes and destroyed for disregarding the warning (1.35–43). The proem has already applied the principle to the companions, who perished "by their own recklessness" (1.7). Solon echoes the speech when he declares that Athens will never perish by the dispensation of Zeus, but that its citizens wish to destroy it by their own folly (fr. 4 West). Hugh Lloyd-Jones (1971) read the passage as evidence of a Homeric justice of Zeus. Both the companions and the suitors fit this juridical register: both are warned—by Teiresias and Circe, by omens and the seer Halitherses—and both die for recklessness.

The fit is not exact, and the poem marks the misfit itself. Amphinomus, the most decent of the suitors, receives from the disguised Odysseus the speech on human frailty

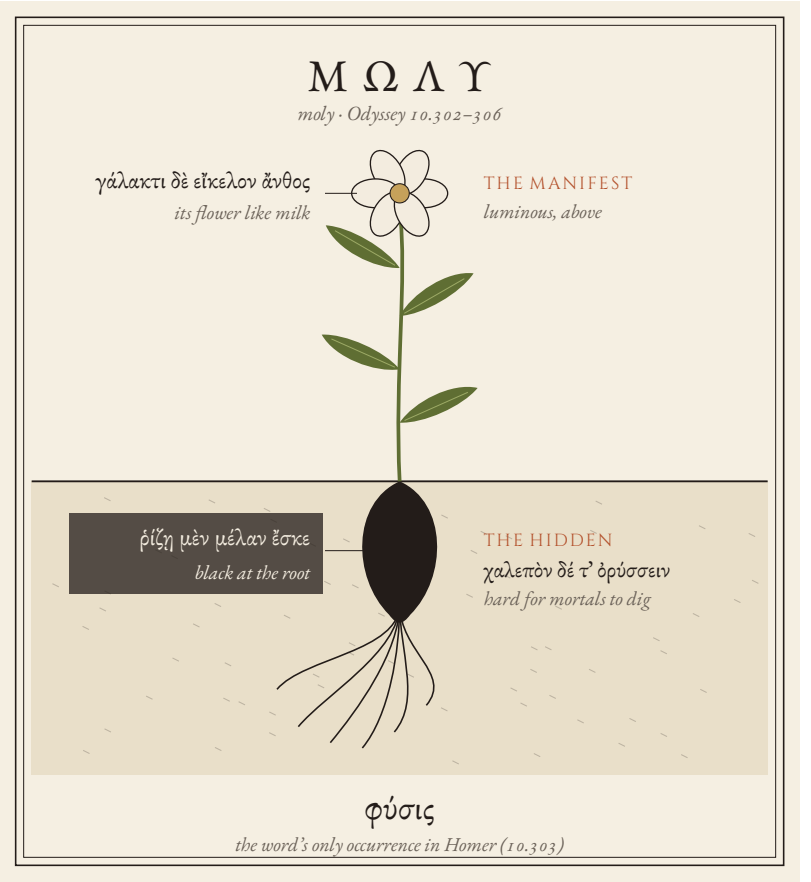


FIGURE 6

Moly, the first physis

Black at the root, its flower like milk, hard for mortal men to dig (10.302–306): the hidden and the manifest, the underground and the luminous (5.4).

quoted in Chapter 2. He walks away troubled, foreseeing evil, "but even so he did not escape his doom, for Athena had bound him to be killed by the hands and spear of Telemachus" (18.153–156); in the battle Telemachus spears him from behind (22.89–94). Leodes, the suitors' seer, pleads that he alone tried to restrain them, and Odysseus beheads him as he pleads (22.310–329). The juridical theodicy announced by Zeus is enforced, at the moment of execution, by a goddess who binds a warned man to his death and by a hero who does not grade degrees of guilt.

The second register is vindictive. Poseidon's persecution of Odysseus is not moral: it avenges a son who ate his guests. Zeus acknowledges the grudge (1.68–75) and later grants Poseidon the punishment of the Phaeacians, whose offense is precisely their

virtue of conveying strangers safely home (8.564–571; 13.125–158). Athena's own wrath, provoked by sacrilege at Troy, lies behind the Achaeans' troubled returns (1.326–327; 3.130–135; 5.105–109). Jenny Strauss Clay (1983) showed that the poem's gods do not form a moral unity.

The third register is proprietary and cosmic. Helios owns seven herds of cattle and seven flocks of sheep, fifty to each, which neither breed nor die (12.127–131): three hundred and fifty animals, read—in an interpretation the scholia attribute to Aristotle—as the days of the lunar year. When the companions eat them, Helios demands compensation and threatens to go down to Hades and shine among the dead (12.377–383). The cosmic order itself is held hostage to the restitution of property, and Zeus destroys the ship. The proem had already stated the consequence: Helios "took from them the day of their return" (ἀφείλετο νόστιμον ἦμαρ, 1.9). If the cattle are days, the companions literally consumed time and lost the day of return—an economy in which the illicit consumption of the sacred forecloses the future.

The result is a fractured theodicy. Three logics of divine causation—juridical, vindictive and proprietary—coexist without synthesis, and Zeus functions less as a lawgiver than as a negotiator among divine jurisdictions. Chapter 8 adds a fourth, aesthetic register (8.577–580). The comparison with Job is instructive: the wager in heaven, the friends' juridical theodicy refuted, the voice from the whirlwind, and the restoration of everything twofold (Job 42:10), which Kierkegaard read in *Repetition* (1843) as the very type of repetition. The *Odyssey*'s restoration is neither double nor gratuitous; it is rewoven at the cost of violence and sealed with amnesty (Chapter 7). Leibniz coined the word *théodicée* in 1710; Voltaire answered him in 1759 with a parodic odyssey (5.7 below).

5.6 *Alimentary Ethics and the Philosophy of the Belly*

The two great transgressions of the poem are acts of eating. The companions eat the cattle of the Sun; the suitors eat Odysseus' flocks and herds, "wearing out the house" (τρύχουσι δὲ οἶκον, 1.248) and devouring it (1.250–251). Both die for consuming what was not theirs to consume. The poem's moral geography is alimentary: the lotus of oblivion, the Cyclops who eats men and drinks unmixed wine, the cannibal Laestrygonians, Circe's drugged potion, the cattle of the Sun, the suitors' endless feast—and, at the center of Ithaca, Eumaeus' meal for a beggar, at which the swineherd sets aside a portion for the Nymphs and for Hermes (14.418–456). How one eats, what one eats and with whom one shares are the boundaries of the human.

Odysseus repeatedly theorizes the belly. At Alcinous' table he asks leave to eat, "for there is nothing more doglike than the hateful belly, which bids a man remember it

Theodicy in Three Registers

three logics of divine causation that coexist without synthesis; a fourth supplements them but does not resolve them



FIGURE 7

Theodicy in three registers

Juridical, vindictive and proprietary-cosmic causation, with Zeus as negotiator among divine jurisdictions (5.5); the aesthetic register of 8.577–580 drawn apart, as a supplement. Helios' medallion counts his seven herds of fifty.

perforce, however afflicted" (7.215–221). To Eumaeus he says that for the sake of the accursed belly men endure evil cares (15.344–345). At his own gate he observes that the ravenous belly cannot be hidden, cursed thing, which brings many evils to men, "for whose sake benched ships are fitted out over the barren sea, bringing evils to enemies" (17.286–289). The belly is the motor of seafaring and war. A materialist anthropology lies at the heart of the poem of mind; Pietro Pucci (1987) made the *gastēr* a key to its poetics.

The idea has a long genealogy. Hesiod's Muses insult shepherds as "mere bellies" (γαστέρες οἶον, *Theog.* 26). Persius' prologue calls the belly the "master of art and bestower of genius" (*magister artis ingenique largitor / venter*, 10–11). Rabelais makes Messere Gaster the "first master of arts in the world" (*Quart Livre* 57). Marx and Engels place at the foundation of all history the fact that humans must be able to live, and therefore to eat and drink, before they can make history at all (*Die deutsche Ideologie*, 1845–46). Brecht condensed the thought into the proposition that grub comes first and morality afterward (1928). The *Odyssey*'s realism of need underlies its idealism of return: the man of *mētis* is the man who knows he has a stomach.

5.7 *The Garden at the End: Candide and Laertes*

Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) is a parodic odyssey of catastrophes aimed at Leibnizian optimism, and its structure reproduces the Odyssean pattern with uncanny fidelity. In Eldorado, a post-scarcity utopia where gold is gravel and there are no courts or prisons, Candide is happy, and he leaves—driven by the wish to see Cunégonde again and to be rich elsewhere. At the end Cunégonde has grown ugly; Candide marries her anyway. The book closes with the instruction to cultivate one's garden.

The correspondences are exact: Eldorado answers to Ogygia and Scheria, the perfect places one leaves; Cunégonde answers to Penelope, the mortal beloved conceded to be lesser in beauty; the garden answers to the orchard of Laertes. The *Odyssey*'s last landscape is an orchard where an old man digs around a plant in a patched tunic, leather greaves and gloves against the thorns, nursing his grief (24.226–231). Recognition there proceeds by the enumeration of trees once given to a child: thirteen pear trees, ten apple trees, forty fig trees, and fifty rows of vines (24.336–344).

Genealogy becomes orchard, inheritance becomes cultivation, and identity becomes the memory of what was planted. The garden is the nostic answer to the problem of evil: not a justification of suffering, but a practice of limited care.

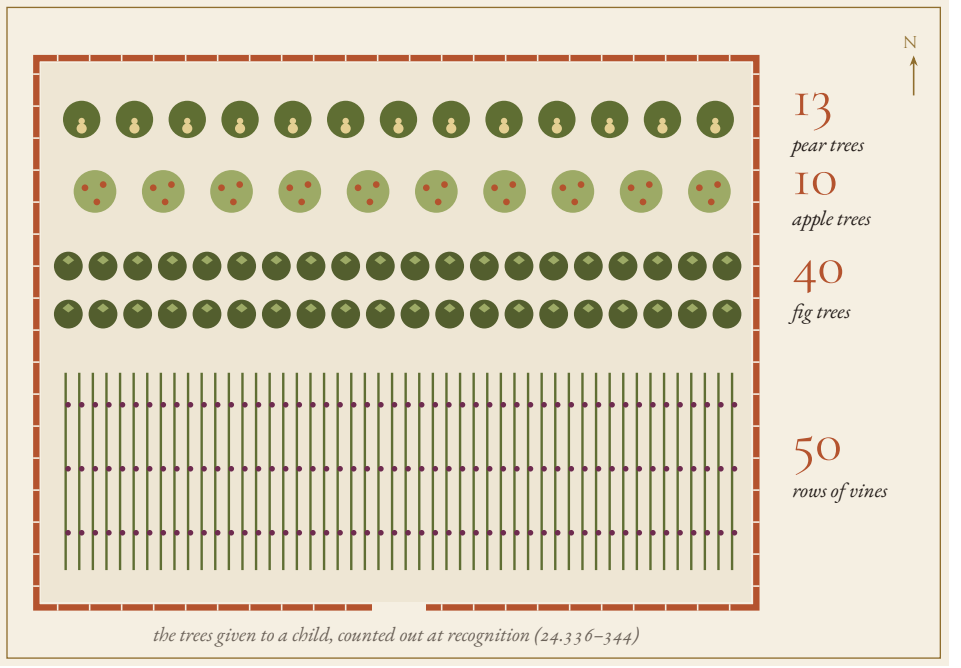
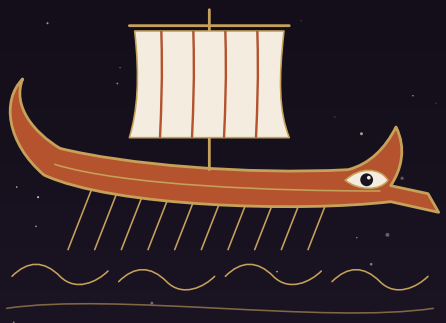


FIGURE 8

The orchard as archive

Thirteen pear trees, ten apple trees, forty fig trees and fifty rows of vines (24.336–344), drawn to their exact counts: genealogy become orchard (5.7).



CHAPTER SIX

Outis and Outopia: Phaeacia, the Thinking Ship, and the Birth of Speculative Fiction

Speculative fiction begins inside the *Odyssey*. Phaeacia is the first techno-utopia; its ships are the first autonomous vessels in literature; and the poem's decision to petrify one of them at the threshold of Ithaca is the founding gesture of a genre that must pass through its utopias in order to come home. This chapter reads Scheria as a post-scarcity, automated society, exposes the paradox at its base, interprets the petrified ship, and traces the descent of the fantastic voyage from the Apologoi to the present.

6.1 *Scheria as Techno-Utopia*

Nausicaa describes the city before Odysseus sees it: high walls, a fine harbor on either side, ships drawn up along the road, an assembly place around the precinct of Poseidon, workshops for cables, sails and oars—for the Phaeacians care nothing for bow and quiver, but for masts and oars and balanced ships (6.262–272). The palace of Alcinous is described as a technological marvel: walls of bronze, a frieze of blue glass-paste, doors of gold on a bronze threshold, doorposts and lintel of silver, a golden handle (7.86–90). Golden youths stand on pedestals holding torches to light the feasting at night (7.100–

102). At the door stand the gold and silver dogs, Hephaestus' work, "deathless and ageless all their days" (7.91–94).

Even the Phaeacians' names are naval. The young men who rise for the games of Book 8 include Eretmeus ("Oarsman"), Nauteus ("Sailor"), Prymneus ("Sternman"), Proreus ("Prowman"), Ponteus ("Seaman"), Anchialus ("Near-the-sea") and Euryalus ("Broad-sea") (8.111–117). A people named for the parts and works of ships—among them a youth called Oarsman—is the people that must be sealed off before an oar can be planted inland.

The orchard beyond the court abolishes season. Pears, pomegranates, apples, figs and olives bear fruit that "never perishes or fails, winter or summer, all the year round," for the West Wind ripens some while it brings others to bud; pear ripens upon pear, apple upon apple, grape upon grape, fig upon fig (7.112–121). In the vineyard, some grapes dry in the sun while others are trodden and others harvested, and unripe clusters are already shedding their flowers (7.122–126). Every stage of the agricultural cycle occurs at once. Production is decoupled from time—post-scarcity in agrarian form.

The ships complete the picture. They are "swift as a wing or a thought" (ὡς εἰ πτερὸν ἠὲ νόημα, 7.36). Alcinous explains how they will carry Odysseus home:

> οὐ γὰρ Φαιήκεσσι κυβερνητῆρες ἔασιν, 557
> οὐδέ τι πηδάλι' ἔστι, τά τ' ἄλλαι νῆες ἔχουσιν· 558
> ἀλλ' αὐταὶ ἴσασι νοήματα καὶ φρένας ἀνδρῶν. 559
>
> (8.557–559)

"For the Phaeacians have no helmsmen, nor are there steering-oars such as other ships have; the ships themselves know the thoughts and minds of men." They know the cities and rich fields of all peoples, cross the gulf of the sea swiftly, hidden in mist and cloud, and never fear damage or destruction (8.560–563).

The helmsman, the *kybernētēs*, gave Norbert Wiener in 1948 the name for the science of control and communication in the animal and the machine: cybernetics. The Phaeacian ship is defined by the helmsman's absence. Its control is internal, and it possesses a complete model of its passenger's intention: it "knows the thoughts and minds of men." It is the first literary description of a machine with a theory of mind.

Three ships of Greek thought can be set side by side. Plato's ship of state needs a philosopher as its *kybernētēs* (*Republic* 6.488a–489a). Clement of Alexandria's ship of salvation is piloted by the divine Word (Chapter 9). The Phaeacian ship needs no pilot at all. Arthur C. Clarke's third law (1973), that any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic, describes the Homeric world exactly. The poem draws no line between *technē* and the divine: Hephaestus' tripods roll of their own accord



PLATO	CLEMENT	PHAEACIA
a philosopher at the helm	*bound to the wood; the Word as pilot*	*no helmsman, no steering-oar*
Republic 6.488a–489a	Protrepticus 12.118	Odyssey 8.557–559

FIGURE 9

Three ships of Greek thought

Plato's ship of state needs a philosopher as its helmsman; Clement's ship of salvation is steered by the Word; the Phaeacian ship needs no pilot at all (6.1). In the manner of red-figure.

to the gods' assembly and his golden handmaids possess mind, voice and strength (*Il.* 18.373–377; 18.417–420). Phaeacia is the place where divine technology is placed in human hands.

6.2 *The Automation Paradox*

In the same palace where machine-dogs never die and ships need no helmsman, fifty slave women grind yellow grain at the mill or weave at the loom and turn the spindle (7.103–107). Automation and servitude coexist. The first techno-utopia is also the first image of their disjunction.

Aristotle formulated the hope this image denies. If each instrument could perform its own work on command or by anticipating what is wanted—like the statues of Daedalus or the tripods of Hephaestus, which, as the poet says, enter the assembly of the gods of their own accord—if shuttles wove and plectra played the lyre by themselves, then master craftsmen would not need assistants nor masters slaves (*Politics* 1253b33–1254a1). The two tasks Aristotle imagines automated, the shuttle and the plectrum, are the two arts of the *Odyssey*: Penelope's loom and the bard's lyre.

Marx quoted the passage in the first volume of *Capital* (1867, chapter 15), together with an epigram of Antipater of Thessalonica (*Anth. Pal.* 9.418) that celebrates the water-mill for freeing the grinding-girls from their toil. He commented ironically

that these pagans understood nothing of political economy: under capital, machinery lengthens the working day rather than shortening it.

The *Odyssey* registers the bottom of this economy with remarkable precision. On the morning of the massacre, of the twelve women who grind barley and wheat day and night for the suitors, the weakest, unable to finish her task, prays to Zeus that this be the suitors' last meal, "for they have loosened my knees with heavy labor grinding meal" (20.105–119). Odysseus takes her prayer as an omen. The poem's lowest laborer pronounces the curse that its hero executes.

The lesson for contemporary techno-utopianism is direct. Automation at the top—thinking ships, immortal guardians—does not imply emancipation at the bottom. The Phaeacian palace stages that disjunction 2,700 years before it became a question of policy.

6.3 *The Petrified Ship*

Alcinous twice recalls a prophecy of his father, Nausithous: Poseidon resents the Phaeacians because they are "escorts without harm" (πομποὶ ἀπήμονες) to all men, and one day he will smite a fine Phaeacian ship on its return voyage and cover their city with a great mountain (8.564–571; 13.172–178). The prophecy is fulfilled immediately after the hero's passage. The Phaeacians set the sleeping Odysseus ashore at the harbor of Phorcys with his treasures beneath an olive (13.113–124). Poseidon complains to Zeus that he will no longer be honored among the gods if mortals—the Phaeacians—show him no regard (13.128–138). Zeus advises: when all the people are watching the ship come in, turn it to stone near the land, in the likeness of a swift ship, so that all men may marvel—and cover their city with a great mountain (13.154–158).

The last clause is a celebrated crux. The vulgate reads μέγα δέ σφιν ὄρος πόλει ἀμφικαλύψαι, "and cover their city with a great mountain," while Aristophanes of Byzantium read μηδέ, "but do not cover it." Poseidon strikes the ship with the flat of his hand and roots it to the sea-floor as stone (13.159–164). The Phaeacians, terrified, recognize the prophecy, resolve never again to convey a mortal, and prepare to sacrifice twelve bulls to Poseidon in the hope that he will not surround their city with a mountain (13.179–184). The narrative leaves them standing around the altar (13.185–187) and never returns. The fate of the first utopia remains literally undecided, suspended between two readings of a single word.

Interpretively, the petrification seals the boundary between the fantastic and the real. Frictionless passage between worlds ends; the vessel becomes a monument, a *sēma* in stone visible from the city. The image is the antitype of the Ship of Theseus, which the Athenians preserved by replacing its rotten timbers until philosophers disputed

whether it remained the same ship (Plutarch, *Theseus* 23.1). Theseus' ship persists in identity through change; the Phaeacian ship is frozen in identity by the end of change. In one tradition the returning hero's vessel becomes a puzzle of continuity; in the other, a monument to the end of passage.

Samuel Butler is the hinge between this scene and modern speculative fiction. In *Erewhon* (1872)—"nowhere" reversed—"The Book of the Machines" argues that machines may evolve consciousness by Darwinian descent, and the Erewhonians accordingly destroy most of their machinery. Butler also translated the *Odyssey* (1900) and argued for its female authorship at Trapani, which he identified with Scheria (1897), so that the utopia became the poem's birthplace.

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) imagines in its deep past a "Butlerian Jihad," a crusade against thinking machines whose name is commonly read as an allusion to Butler, and whose commandment forbids making a machine in the likeness of a human mind. Herbert's ruling house, the Atreides, claims descent from Atreus, whose house supplies the *Odyssey*'s counter-paradigm of the poisoned homecoming. Poseidon's act is the first Butlerian closure: the god of the sea turns the thinking ship into stone.

6.4 *The Apologoi and the Genealogy of the Fantastic Voyage*

The four books Odysseus narrates at Alcinous' court (9–12) became proverbial. Plato introduces the Myth of Er with a pun: "It is not a tale of Alcinous (Ἀλκίνου γε ἀπόλογον) that I will tell you, but that of a valiant man (ἀλκίμου), Er" (*Republic* 614b). The philosophical myth defines itself against the Apologoi—and ends, as Chapter 4 showed, with Odysseus' soul choosing obscurity.

Lucian's *True History* (second century CE) names Homer's Odysseus as the founder and teacher of this kind of charlatanry, who told Alcinous and his court of winds held in bondage, one-eyed men, cannibals and savages, many-headed beasts and comrades transformed by drugs, and so deceived the simple Phaeacians (1.3). Lucian then narrates a voyage to the Moon, an interplanetary war, a sojourn in a whale's belly and a visit to the Isle of the Blessed. The work often called the earliest extant science fiction is an explicit Odyssean parody, and it contains Odysseus himself (2.29; 2.35).

Thomas More's *Utopia* (1516) introduces its traveler Raphael Hythloday as one who has sailed not like Palinurus but like Ulysses, or rather like Plato. The island's name, *ou-topos*, "no place," shares its negative particle with *Outis*. The speculative tradition's person and place are both negations: no one, nowhere. Phaeacia—which no mortal reaches without the gods (6.201–205) and which closes itself after the hero's passage—is the first Outopia.

Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) rewrites the Apologoi as satire. In Book 3, Laputa, the flying island of mathematicians and projectors, recalls Aeolus' floating island (πλωτῇ ἐνὶ νήσῳ, 10.3) with its closed, endogamous household. Glubbdubdrib, where sorcerers summon the dead, recalls the Nekyia: Gulliver calls up Homer and Aristotle and finds their commentators too ashamed to face them. Luggnagg's Struldbruggs travesty Calypso's offer. Book 4 inverts the nostos itself. Returning from the rational horses, Gulliver cannot bear his wife and children, buys two horses and converses with them daily. It is the anti-*homophrosynē*: a homecoming that fails because the voyager can no longer recognize his own kind.

Fénelon's *Les Aventures de Télémaque* (1699) continues the Telemachy as a mirror for princes. Mentor, who is Minerva in disguise, guides Telemachus through Bétique, a pastoral society without money or property, and Salente, a city reformed under his counsel. The Telemachy becomes a manual of political speculation.

Verne's Nautilus (1869–70) is a Phaeacian ship under an Outis: self-sufficient, drawing its power from the sea, carrying a library and a museum, it is a complete world. Its captain, Nemo, holds his guests until they escape through the Maelstrom, Charybdis modernized (Chapter 2).

H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) carries the pattern into deep time. In the year 802,701 the Time Traveller finds humanity divided into the Eloi—beautiful, childlike and idle above ground—and the Morlocks, pale and subterranean, who tend machines and feed on the Eloi. The *Odyssey*'s twin golden-age peoples, the Phaeacians and the Cyclopes, who lived side by side until the stronger harmed the weaker (6.4–10), reappear as two branches of a single future species, and the Traveller fights the cave-dwellers with fire as Odysseus blinded the Cyclops with a fire-hardened stake. At the end he departs again and does not return—a Dantean ending. He leaves behind only two strange white flowers that Weena had put in his pocket: the *sēma* of an unverifiable voyage, a token that, like the Phaeacian treasures, testifies to a world no one else can visit.

6.5 *Twentieth- and Twenty-First-Century Odysseys*

Clarke and Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) names its lineage in its title. The ship's computer, HAL 9000, represented by a single red lens, kills the crew; David Bowman—whose surname names the archer—disables it by removing its memory modules while, in Kubrick's film, it regresses into singing "Daisy Bell." The one-eyed giant becomes a Siren as it dies. Bowman then passes through the Star Gate and returns as the Star Child orbiting the Earth: a gnostic nostos, the return to the planet as a transfigured being.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) imagines an ocean-planet that reads the minds of the station's scientists and materializes "visitors" from their memories, among them Kelvin's dead lover, Harey. The ocean is at once Proteus, the shape-shifting Old Man of the Sea who must be held fast (4.351–570), and Calypso, for it offers the beloved again. The visitors, however, are deathless simulacra: they regenerate after injury, their dresses have no fastenings, they have no past to share. Like Alcinous' dogs, they are ageless and deathless, and so they cannot truly recognize or be recognized. Kelvin, unlike Odysseus, chooses at the end to remain on Solaris, waiting in the faith that the age of cruel miracles has not passed: the Calypsonian choice, made in full knowledge.

Iain M. Banks's Culture novels, beginning with *Consider Phlebas* (1987), imagine a post-scarcity civilization governed by vastly intelligent ship-Minds with whimsical names: Phaeacia at galactic scale, including its ambivalences, for the Culture's covert interventions abroad trouble its benevolence. Dan Simmons's *Ilium* (2003) and *Olympos* (2005) stage post-humans re-enacting the Trojan War on Mars in the guise of Homeric gods—Clarke's law applied to the pantheon.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) follows the physicist Shevek from the anarchist moon Anarres to the propertarian planet Urras and back. Its chapters alternate between past and present until the two strands converge on the return, and its governing phrase is "true journey is return." The structure reproduces the *Odyssey*'s ring composition: a beginning *in medias res*, an embedded retrospect, a convergence on homecoming.

Kim Stanley Robinson's *Aurora* (2015) is the most explicitly nostic novel of the genre. A generation ship reaches Tau Ceti; the colony founded on a moon called Aurora—Dawn, Eos, the immortal lover of Tithonus—fails because of a lethal biological agent; part of the population turns back toward Earth. The narrator is the ship's artificial intelligence, instructed to compose an account of the voyage, which comes through the labor of narration to something like selfhood: the Phaeacian ship acquires a voice. The novel ends on an Earth beach, with the returned protagonist entering the surf. Robinson has argued publicly that there is no second Earth to escape to.

6.6 *The Phaeacian Genre*

Speculative fiction is the Phaeacian genre. Its estrangement, in Suvin's sense, is the mist in which the ships travel unseen; its cognition is the Apologoi's realism of detail—bronze walls, exact counts of animals, the mechanics of a bag of winds. The genre's fundamental bifurcation reproduces the poem's choice. The *novum* may be a destination, as in the colony, the upload or the transcendence that is never left; or it may be a

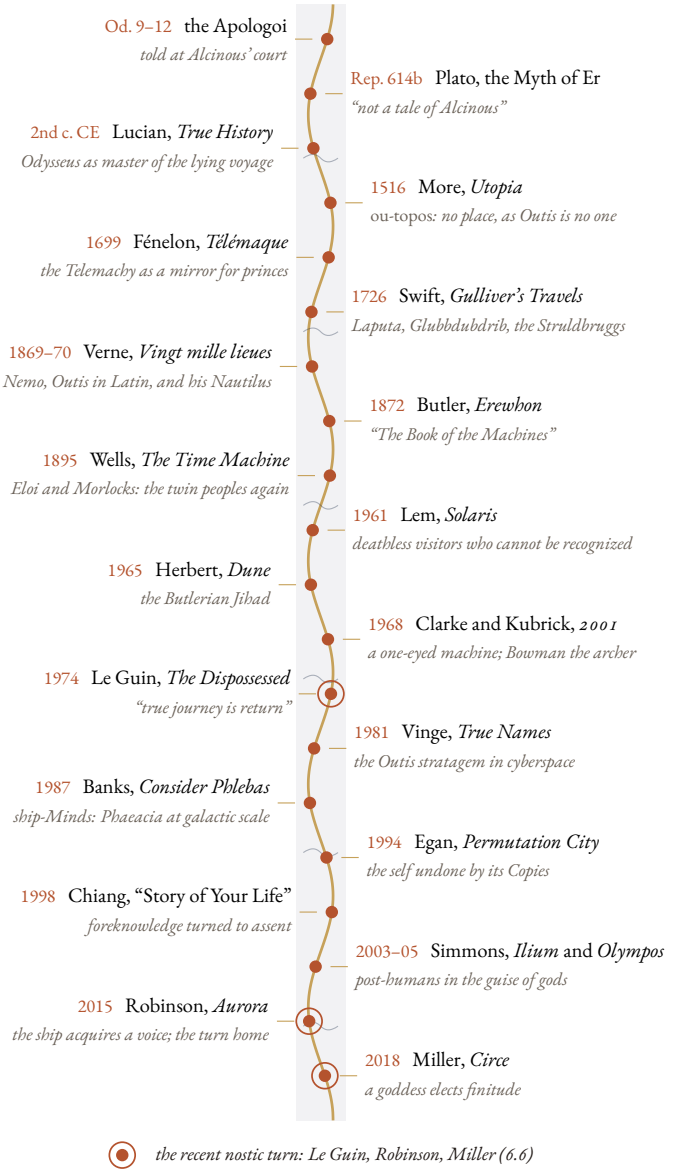


FIGURE 10

The Phaeacian genre

A selection of the voyages Chapter 6 traces from the Apologoi to the present; ringed, the recent nostic turn named in 6.6.

detour—the utopia passed through, petrified behind the traveler, and remembered as a story told at a stranger's table.

The *Odyssey* supplies the paradigm of the second. Odysseus does not stay in Phaeacia, though Alcinous wishes he would marry Nausicaa and remain (7.311–316). He passes through it, receives its gifts, sleeps through its magic, and wakes on a shore he does not recognize. The recent nostic turn in the genre—Le Guin, Robinson, Miller—answers an ecological and technological situation in which the *novum* increasingly appears not as escape but as threshold.



CHAPTER SEVEN

Xenia, Violence, and Amnesty: The Political Philosophy of Return

The *Odyssey*'s political philosophy rests on a paradox. Its ethics of hospitality defers the demand for identity and shelters the stranger, yet its restoration of the household is accomplished by a purge and secured by a divinely commanded oblivion. This chapter reconstructs the hospitality protocol, reads the suitors as domestic Cyclopes, confronts the massacre and the hanging of twelve enslaved women, considers the enslaved for whom no return exists and the veteran for whom return is itself a wound, examines nostalgia as a political passion, and interprets the amnesty that ends the poem.

7.1 *Hospitality as Deferred Identification*

Steve Reece (1993) reconstructed the hospitality type-scene from its many instances in the poem: arrival, reception, seating, feast, and only then the question of the stranger's identity, followed by entertainment, bed, gifts and conveyance. The order is normative. Telemachus greets the disguised Athena: "Welcome, stranger; you shall be entertained among us, and when you have tasted dinner you shall tell us what you need" (1.123–124). Nestor waits until his guests have eaten: "now it is more fitting to ask who they are, since they have had their pleasure of food" (3.69–70). Menelaus says the same (4.60–

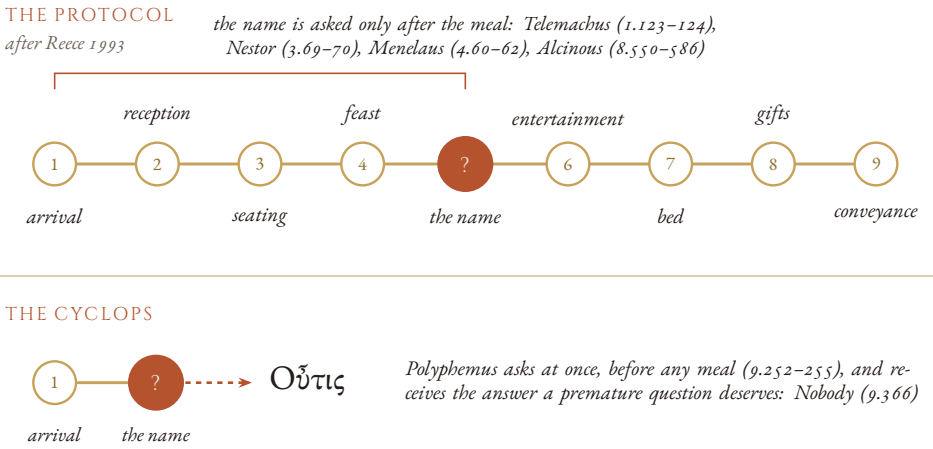


FIGURE 11

Hospitality as deferred identification

The type-scene reconstructed by Reece (1993): the stranger is fed before he is asked his name (7.1). The Cyclops inverts the order and is answered accordingly.

62). Alcinous lets days of feasting, games and song pass before he asks Odysseus his name (8.550–586). The guest's identity is the last thing the host requires, not the first.

Derrida (*De l'hospitalité*, 1997) distinguished an unconditional hospitality, which welcomes the newcomer without asking a name, from the conditional hospitality of rights and duties, which begins by asking who one is. The Homeric protocol is a historically real approximation of the unconditional. It does not abolish the question, but it defers it until after nourishment.

Polyphemus violates the order. He asks at once, before any meal, "Strangers, who are you? From where do you sail the watery ways?" (9.252–255)—and he receives the answer the premature question deserves: Outis. Anonymity is the just response to a premature demand for identity. Odysseus gives his true name to the Phaeacians only after they have fed, honored and entertained him (9.19–20). The name is a gift to a host who has earned it.

Kant's *Perpetual Peace* (1795), in its Third Definitive Article, limited cosmopolitan right to universal hospitality: the stranger's right not to be treated with hostility on arrival, a right of visit (*Besuchsrecht*) rather than a right to be a guest (*Gastrecht*). The Homeric host gives more than Kant's right and less than Derrida's absolute: he gives food, bed, gifts and conveyance, and expects in return the name and the story.

The sanction is religious. Eumaeus, receiving the beggar, says that it is not right for him to dishonor a stranger, even one meaner than this, "for all strangers and beggars are from Zeus" (πρὸς γὰρ Διός εἰσιν ἅπαντες / ξεῖνοί τε πτωχοί τε, 14.56–58). When

Antinous strikes the beggar, another suitor warns him that the gods, in the likeness of strangers from abroad, take every shape and wander the cities, observing the insolence and the good order of men (ὕβριν τε καὶ εὐνομίην ἐφορῶντες, 17.483–487).

The theology of theoxeny—the god as disguised guest—is shared with Abraham's reception of the three visitors at Mamre (Genesis 18), with Ovid's Baucis and Philemon, who feed Jupiter and Mercury unawares (*Metamorphoses* 8.611–724), and with the Christian injunction to hospitality, since thereby some have entertained angels unawares (Hebrews 13:2). The ethical consequence is radical. Since any stranger might be a god, every stranger must be treated as though he were one: epistemic uncertainty about identity becomes the ground of an ethical universalism. Glissant's right to opacity (Chapter 2) is its secular heir.

7.2 *The Suitors as Domestic Cyclopes*

The poem constructs the suitors as Cyclopes inside the house. Both offer mock guest-gifts. Polyphemus promises to eat Outis last—"this will be your guest-gift" (τὸ δέ τοι ξεινήιον ἔσται, 9.370)—and Ctesippus, hurling an ox-hoof at the beggar, calls it his guest-gift (ξείνιον, 20.296–302). Antinous strikes the beggar with a footstool (17.462–465); Eurymachus throws another (18.394–397). Both consume the property of an absent other: the Cyclops eats the strangers, the suitors eat the host. The blinding of Polyphemus and the slaughter of the suitors are structurally one act, the reassertion of *xenia* against those who invert it.

The suitors also embody a political vacuum. When Telemachus convenes an assembly in Book 2, the aged Aegyptius observes that there has been neither assembly nor council since Odysseus sailed (2.26–27). Twenty years of interregnum have reduced the polity to the household, and the household to a feeding-ground. Hannah Arendt's distinction (*The Human Condition*, 1958) between the household, the realm of necessity, and the polis, the realm of freedom, is illuminated by the crisis: without sovereign or assembly, the public realm collapses into appetite. The suitors represent politics reduced to consumption.

Arendt's threefold division of the active life maps onto the poem with unusual exactness. *Labor*, the endless cycle of sustaining life, belongs to Laertes digging in his orchard, to Eumaeus among his swine, and to the women grinding grain. *Work*, the making of durable things that outlast their makers, belongs to the raft, the bow and above all the bed. *Action*, the speech and deed that disclose who someone is and that only others can witness and retell, belongs to the hall of Alcinous, where Odysseus at last names himself and tells his story to listeners who will remember it (9.19–20). The

suitors do none of these: they neither labor nor make, and their speech in assembly is the speech of consumers.

The poem's constant counter-paradigm is the house of Atreus. Zeus opens his theodicy with Aegisthus (1.35–43); Athena urges Telemachus to emulate the fame of Orestes (1.298–302); Nestor and Menelaus retell the murder (3.193–200; 3.306–310; 4.512–537); Agamemnon's shade narrates it to Odysseus and counsels secrecy on his own return (11.405–456); and the poem's final judgment sets Penelope against Clytemnestra (24.192–202). The *Odyssey* is written against the Oresteia it presupposes: the homecoming that ends in murder.

7.3 *The Bow and the Lyre: The Massacre*

The climax is a simile. As a man skilled in the lyre and in song easily stretches a string around a new peg, fastening the twisted sheep-gut at both ends, so without effort Odysseus strung the great bow; then he tested the string with his right hand, and it sang sweetly under his touch, like a swallow in voice (21.404–411). Zeus thunders (21.413).

Heraclitus wrote that men do not understand how what differs agrees with itself: there is a back-turning harmony, as of the bow and the lyre (παλίντροπος ἁρμονίη ὅκωσπερ τόξου καὶ λύρης, DK B51; the fragment is also transmitted with παλίντονος, "back-stretched"). Whether or not Heraclitus had Book 21 in mind—bow and lyre are also Apollo's attributes, and the slaughter takes place on the god's festival day (20.276–278; 21.258–259)—the convergence is philosophically decisive. The poem's climax fuses the instrument of song and the instrument of death in a single gesture, and Heraclitus names the principle: palintropy, the back-turning of tension, the harmony of opposites. The many turnings of the polytropic hero resolve into a palintropic return. Seth Benardete's Platonic reading of the poem takes its title, *The Bow and the Lyre* (1997), from this convergence.

The massacre follows (22.1–389), and the poem names its agents. Odysseus shoots Antinous through the throat as he lifts a cup (22.8–21). Eurymachus tries to negotiate, blaming the dead Antinous and offering restitution of twenty oxen from each suitor; Odysseus refuses and shoots him (22.45–88). Telemachus spears Amphinomus from behind (22.89–94). Odysseus beheads the suppliant Leodes, the suitors' seer, as he pleads that he restrained the others (22.310–329). Odysseus spares Phemius, a self-taught singer inspired by a god, when Telemachus vouches that he sang under compulsion, and spares the herald Medon with him (22.330–377). The voice and the message are exempt from the purge: the poem saves its own medium.

The Bow and the Lyre



παλίντροπος ἁρμονίη ὅκωσπερ τόξου καὶ λύρης

"a back-turning harmony, as of the bow and the lyre" — Heraclitus, DK B51

Odysseus strings the great bow as a singer strings a new peg; it sings under his hand like a swallow, and Zeus thunders (21.404–413)

FIGURE 12

The bow and the lyre

The climax fuses the instrument of song and the instrument of death in a single gesture (21.404–411); Heraclitus names the principle (7.3).

Then the enslaved women. Odysseus had announced his intention to kill them three books earlier, while threatening Eurycleia (19.489–490). Now he asks her which of the fifty women of the house have dishonored him, and she names twelve, who had "set foot on shamelessness," defied Penelope and Eurycleia, and slept with the suitors (22.417–427). At the start of the battle Odysseus had himself charged the suitors with bedding the slave women "by force" (βιαίως, 22.37); elsewhere the poem presents some of the women, Melantho above all, as willing partners (18.320–325; 20.6–8). Either way they were enslaved, in a house ruled for years by the men they are punished for having slept with.

Odysseus orders Telemachus, Eumaeus and Philoetius to make the women carry out the corpses and scrub the hall, and then to kill them with swords (22.435–445). The three drive the women into a narrow space between the round-house and the courtyard wall. Telemachus chooses a crueler death—"let me not take their lives by a clean death" (μὴ μὲν δὴ καθαρῷ θανάτῳ, 22.462)—fastens a ship's cable to a pillar, throws it around the round-house, and hangs all twelve. As when long-winged thrushes or doves rush into a net set in a thicket, so they held their heads in a row; their feet twitched for a little while, not long (22.457–473). The same three men then take the goatherd Melanthius, whom Eumaeus and Philoetius had earlier, on Odysseus' orders, hoisted bound to the rafters while Eumaeus mocked him (22.171–199). They cut off his nose and ears, castrate him and throw his genitals to the dogs, and cut off his hands and feet (22.474–477). Odysseus then fumigates the hall with sulfur and fire (22.481–494).

The instrument of the women's death is a ship's cable (πεῖσμα νεὸς κυανοπρῴροιο, 22.465): the technology of the voyage comes home as an instrument of domestic execution. The narrative is cold—a simile of birds in a net, a note on duration. Horkheimer and Adorno singled out precisely this coolness as the sign of a reason that has become pure domination. Margaret Atwood's *The Penelopiad* (2005) gives the twelve hanged women a chorus, which she calls the Maids—songs, a trial, an anthropology lecture—and makes Penelope complicit in their fate. Emily Wilson's translation (2017) refuses the misogynistic slurs earlier translators supplied for them, rendering them with the Greek's social precision as enslaved women, and her introduction exposes the asymmetries of power that earlier versions had naturalized.

The ethical charge is unavoidable: the nostic order of the poem is founded in purgative violence. Svetlana Boym's distinction between restorative and reflective nostalgia (2001) names the danger. A nostalgia that seeks to rebuild the lost home exactly must purge whoever now occupies it.

7.4 *Slavery and the Anti-Nostos*

Eumaeus was born a prince, son of Ctesius, king of Syrie. As a child he was carried off by a Phoenician slave-woman of his father's house, who sold him with stolen goods to Phoenician traders; she died at sea, and he was sold to Laertes (15.403–484). Eurycleia was bought by Laertes for twenty oxen and honored like a wife, though he never took her to bed, for fear of his wife's anger (1.429–433). Odysseus promises Eumaeus and the cowherd Philoetius, if the god subdues the suitors, wives, property and houses near his own, and that they shall be companions and brothers to Telemachus (21.213–216).

The poem knows the homelessness of the enslaved and imagines a partial remedy: adoption into the master's household. It never imagines the slave's return to his own. Eumaeus is a nostos foreclosed: a prince of Syrie whom no one at home remembers, who has made a home of his servitude, and whose piety and hospitality exceed those of the free. He is the poem's figure of the archive that failed: no one kept his signs.

The historical negation of nostos is the transatlantic slave trade. Between the early sixteenth century and the 1860s, Portuguese and Brazilian, British, French, Spanish, Dutch, Danish and North American traders, supplied by African rulers and merchants, carried about 12.5 million enslaved Africans across the Atlantic, of whom about 10.7 million survived the crossing, according to the standard estimates of the Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database. Dionne Brand's *A Map to the Door of No Return* (2001) takes its title from the doors of the slave forts of the West African coast, through which captives passed never to return. Paul Gilroy's *The Black Atlantic* (1993) made the ship a chronotope of modernity, a moving site of loss and connection. Derek Walcott's *Omeros* (1990) rewrites Homer among the fishermen of St. Lucia—Achille, Hector, Helen, and a blind seer called Seven Seas—and grants Achille a dream-voyage across the Atlantic to the Africa of his ancestors: a nostos possible only in vision, after which he returns to the island that is now his home. Walcott's Caribbean answer to the *Odyssey* is that home is where the wound is tended, not where it began.

7.5 *Trauma and the Veteran's Return*

Jonathan Shay, a psychiatrist who treated Vietnam veterans, read the *Iliad* as an anatomy of combat trauma (*Achilles in Vietnam*, 1994) and the *Odyssey* as a narrative of the veteran's homecoming (*Odysseus in America*, 2002). On his reading, the hero's distrust, hypervigilance and lying, his loss of every man under his command, and his violence on return are recognizable sequelae of prolonged combat; the massacre in the hall is the war brought home. Shay stresses the healing value of what he calls the communalization of trauma: the telling of the story to a community that listens.

The Phaeacian court is its archetype. Odysseus weeps at Demodocus' songs (8.83–95; 8.521–531); asked his name, he narrates his sufferings to an audience held spellbound in the shadowy hall (11.333–334; 13.1–2); only after the telling is he conveyed home. The poem enacts the sequence Shay recommends: narrative before reintegration.

The simile at 8.521–531 is also the poem's acknowledgment of what clinicians now call moral injury. The sacker of Troy weeps like a woman who falls over her husband killed before his city, while the enemy beat her back and shoulders with spears and lead her away to slavery. In the instant of hearing his triumph sung, the victor feels the grief of the vanquished.

The acknowledgment does not last. In the next book, opening his narrative to the same audience, Odysseus reports without any such grief that on leaving Troy he sacked Ismarus, the city of the Cicones, killed its men, and took their wives and possessions to divide among his crew (9.39–42). The man who wept as the captive widow had made captive widows of his own.

7.6 *Nostalgia as a Political Passion*

The word *nostalgia* was coined in 1688 by the medical student Johannes Hofer, in a Basel dissertation, from *nostos* and *algos*, to name a homesickness that afflicted Swiss soldiers serving abroad and was believed capable of killing. Anticleia, who died of longing for her son (11.202–203), is its first literary case. Boym (2001) distinguished restorative nostalgia, which seeks to reconstruct the lost home and grounds nationalist revivals, from reflective nostalgia, which dwells in longing itself, with irony and awareness of loss.

The *Odyssey* contains both. Odysseus' bow is restorative nostalgia: the reassertion of origin by force. Penelope's loom is reflective nostalgia: the suspension of time in a labor of mourning that can be undone and redone. The poem's political intelligence lies in its refusal to let either stand alone.

7.7 *Eklēsis: The Amnesty That Founds the Polity*

In the last book Eupeithes, father of Antinous, rouses the Ithacans to avenge their sons (24.420–438); Medon and Halitherses argue against him (24.439–462); the families arm and march (24.463–471). Athena asks Zeus what he intends, and Zeus answers that, since Odysseus has taken vengeance, they should swear oaths and he should be king all his days:

ἡμεῖς δ' αὖ παίδων τε κασιγνήτων τε φόνοιο 484

ἔκλησιν θέωμεν· τοὶ δ' ἀλλήλους φιλεόντων 485
ὡς τὸ πάρος, πλοῦτος δὲ καὶ εἰρήνη ἅλις ἔστω. 486

(24.484–486)

"And let us bring about a forgetting of the slaughter of their sons and brothers; and let them love one another as before, and let there be wealth and peace in abundance." Laertes kills Eupeithes with a spear (24.520–525); Odysseus and his son begin to cut down the rest; Athena cries out, the Ithacans flee, Zeus' thunderbolt halts Odysseus, and Athena, in the likeness of Mentor, sets oaths between the two sides (24.526–548). The poem ends.

The decree is the first amnesty in literature. In 403 BCE the restored Athenian democracy, emerging from the regime of the Thirty, swore not to recall past wrongs (μὴ μνησικακεῖν). Nicole Loraux (*La cité divisée*, 1997) showed that the Athenian amnesty founded civic unity on an institutionalized forgetting of civil war, at the price of repressing the memory of division. Ricoeur (*La Mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*, 2000) analyzed amnesty as commanded forgetting and warned that it borders on amnesia: it may serve civic peace while betraying the dead.

The *Odyssey*'s amnesty must be read against its other forgettings. The lotus makes men forget their return (9.94–97); Circe's drug aims at the oblivion of the homeland (10.236); Helen's Egyptian drug makes grief forgotten (4.219–232). These are private forgettings that destroy or anaesthetize the return. Zeus' *eklēsis* is a public forgetting that makes the return politically possible.

Italo Calvino read the poem's dangers in the same key. The lotus, Circe's drugs and the Sirens' song are all, he argued, threats of forgetting, and the memory that matters holds together the trace of the past and the project of the future ("Le Odissee nell'Odissea," 1981; in *Perché leggere i classici*, Milan: Mondadori, 1991). The amnesty of Book 24 is the one forgetting the poem sanctions, and it is sanctioned precisely because it serves a future.

The poem therefore ends on a double requirement: perfect private memory—the bed, the scar, the orchard, the signs that make recognition possible—and decreed public oblivion, the amnesty that makes coexistence possible after the purge. The nostic polity rests on remembering everything in the bedchamber and forgetting the hall.

The dissonance is not resolved; it is suspended by divine force. Athena intervenes at the limit of the human capacity to end vengeance. Aeschylus' *Eumenides* (458 BCE) ends the Atreid cycle through the same goddess—but by an institution, the court of the Areopagus, and by the persuasion of the Furies, rather than by oblivion. The two Athenas offer two founding acts of politics: the Odyssean, which ends violence by forgetting, and the Aeschylean, which ends it by judgment. Athens, in 403, chose both.



CHAPTER EIGHT

The Loom and the Lyre: Penelopean Poetics and the Ethics of Listening

Against the bow's irreversible discharge the poem sets Penelope's loom, an art of reversible time, and around both it builds a theory of song as remedy and danger, as justification of suffering and as hospitality to it. This chapter reads the web, the dream and the contest as Penelope's poetics; the reverse similes as the figurative form of *homophrosynē*; Helen's drug and the Sirens' song as the poem's pharmacology of narrative; and Alcinous' aesthetic theodicy as the origin of an ethics of listening.

8.1 *The Web That Unweaves Time*

The web is narrated three times: by Antinous, the adversary, in the Ithacan assembly (2.93–110); by Penelope, its author, to the disguised Odysseus (19.137–156); and by Amphimedon, a dead suitor, to Agamemnon in the underworld (24.128–146). The stratagem is the same in each. Penelope sets up a great loom and weaves a shroud for Laertes, telling the suitors that she will choose a husband when it is finished; by day she weaves, and by night, by torchlight, she unweaves; for three years she deceives them, until in the fourth a maid betrays her. Told by the enemy, by the author, and by a victim

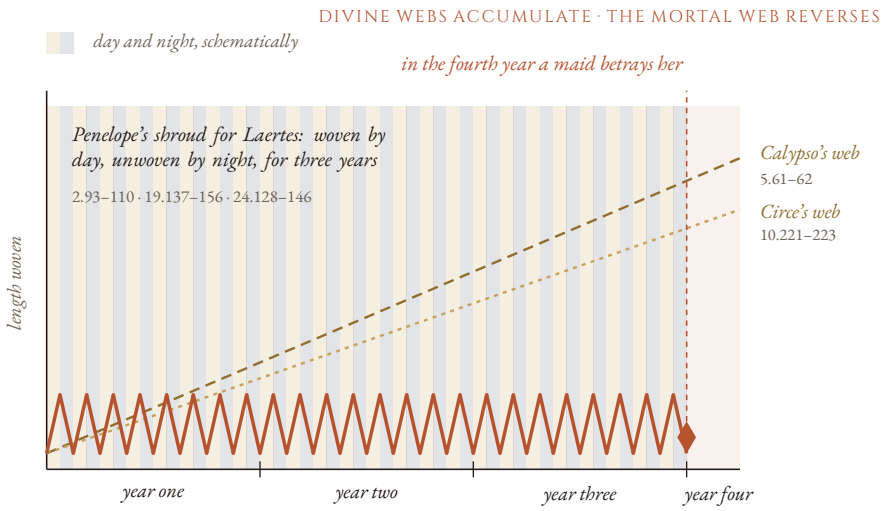


FIGURE 13

The web that unweaves time

Divine weaving accumulates; mortal weaving resists the irreversible (8.1). The teeth are schematic, not a count of days.

among the dead, the web is the poem's most narrated object, and each telling places it in a different economy—as fraud, as cunning, as cause of death.

The object is a shroud. Penelope defers her remarriage by weaving the burial garment of her father-in-law: death's textile is used to postpone the future. The web makes time reversible, since what is done by day is undone by night; the suitors' time is consumed while Penelope's is held in suspension. Against the bow, whose arrows cannot be recalled, the loom is the poem's figure of reversible action.

Chapter 4 noted that Calypso and Circe also weave at their looms (5.61–62; 10.221–223) and never unweave. Divine weaving accumulates; mortal weaving resists the irreversible. Penelope's art is the *technē* of finitude: it uses limited time to suspend time's demand.

The textile is also a text. In the *Iliad*, Helen weaves into a purple web the struggles of Trojans and Achaeans that they suffered for her sake (*Il.* 3.125–128): weaving is already narrative. Barbara Clayton (2004) reads Penelope's web as the figure of a Penelopean poetics—composition by undoing, an aesthetic of revision. Feminist scholarship (Murnaghan 1987; Winkler 1990; Katz 1991; Felson 1994; Zeitlin 1995) has made Penelope the poem's second intelligence and its most indeterminate figure, whose knowledge and intentions the narrative deliberately withholds.

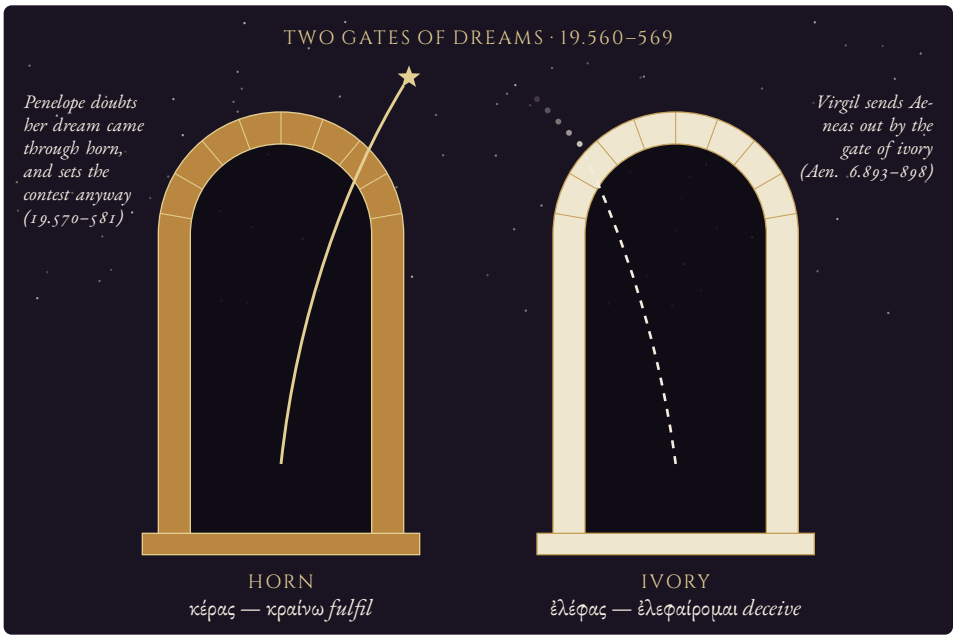


FIGURE 14

The gates of horn and ivory

Dreams through polished horn come true, those through ivory deceive, by a pair of puns (19.560–569); Penelope decides under radical uncertainty (8.2).

8.2 *The Dream of the Geese and the Gates of Horn and Ivory*

Penelope tells the disguised Odysseus a dream (19.535–553). Twenty geese in her house were eating grain from a trough, and she delighted to watch them; an eagle swooped from the mountain and broke their necks; she wept, and the women of Achaea gathered round her. Then the eagle returned, perched on the roof-beam, and spoke in a human voice: the geese are the suitors, and I, who was an eagle, am now your husband. The dream interprets itself—and the dreamer weeps for the geese. Whether Penelope mourns the attentions of courtship she has enjoyed is among the poem's most debated psychological questions, and the text declines to settle it.

The beggar confirms the dream's meaning; Penelope remains skeptical. Dreams are hard to interpret, she says, and not all come true. There are two gates of dreams, one of horn and one of ivory: those that come through ivory deceive, those through polished horn come true (19.560–569). The gates are named by puns—ivory, *elephas*, with deception, *elephairomai*; horn, *keras*, with fulfillment, *krainō*. She doubts that her dream came through horn.

Then, in the same speech, she announces the contest of the bow (19.570–581). This is decision under radical uncertainty: the dream may be false and the beggar a liar, and she acts anyway. Virgil inherited the gates and sent Aeneas out of the underworld through the gate of ivory, the gate of false dreams (*Aeneid* 6.893–898), in the most enigmatic line of his poem. The oneiric epistemology of Book 19 is the *Odyssey*'s doctrine of the limits of knowledge.

8.3 *The Contest as Penelope's Design*

Penelope fetches the bow from the storeroom herself (21.1–79), and the poem tells its history. It was a gift from Iphitus, whom Odysseus met in Messene. Iphitus later went in search of lost mares to Heracles, who killed him in his own house, though he was his guest, respecting neither the anger of the gods nor the table he had set before him (21.11–41). The bow carries in its genealogy a violation of *xenia*, and it becomes the instrument of *xenia*'s restoration. Instruments in the poem bear their histories as signs.

The contest belongs to the Homecoming-Husband type and has its Indian parallel in Damayantī's sham *svayaṃvara* (Chapter 3). In both cases the wife designs a contest that only the true husband can win, and so convokes his return. The contest is a recognition device disguised as a remarriage.

The poem's gender politics crystallize around it. Telemachus twice dismisses his mother. In Book 1 he sends her back to her loom: "speech shall be the concern of men, and of me most of all, for mine is the power in this house" (μῦθος δ' ἄνδρεσσι μελήσει, 1.356–359). In Book 21, as the beggar takes up the bow, he repeats the formula: "the bow shall be the concern of men" (τόξον δ' ἄνδρεσσι μελήσει, 21.350–353). The two formulas exclude Penelope from the two instruments of public power, speech and weapon. Mary Beard (2017) opens her account of the silencing of women's public voice with the first of these passages.

Yet the poem undercuts its young man. Penelope's speech convokes the contest, and Penelope's test closes the recognition. The bow is men's concern; the decision when it shall be drawn is hers.

8.4 *Reverse Similes and Homophrosynē as Poetics*

Helene Foley (1978) identified a series of "reverse similes" that compare men to women and women to men across the line of gender. When Demodocus sings the sack of Troy, Odysseus weeps as a woman weeps, falling upon her husband who has died before his city, while the enemy beat her back and shoulders with spears and lead her off to bondage (8.523–530). When Penelope at last embraces her husband, he is as welcome

to her as land to swimmers whose ship Poseidon has smashed at sea, who struggle to the shore crusted with brine and rejoice to set foot on land, escaped from evil (23.233–240). And the disguised Odysseus praises Penelope's fame as that of a blameless king who upholds justice, so that the black earth bears wheat and barley, the trees are heavy with fruit and the sea yields fish (19.108–114).

The pattern is exact. The conqueror receives the simile of the captive widow; the faithful wife receives the simile of the shipwrecked sailor, which is her husband's own experience; the queen receives the simile of the just king. Husband and wife share each other's sufferings in figure before they share the bed. *Homophrosynē*, "like-mindedness" (6.180–185), is realized at the level of figuration: the poem's similes make each spouse live the other's experience. It is a poetics of reciprocity.

8.5 *Song as Pharmakon*

At Sparta, Helen casts into the wine a drug from Egypt, a gift of Polydamna, wife of Thon, from a land whose earth bears many drugs, some healing and some baneful. It is νηπενθές τ' ἄχολόν τε, κακῶν ἐπίληθον ἁπάντων, "a drug against grief and anger, bringing forgetfulness of every evil" (4.219–232); whoever drinks it would shed no tear that day, though his mother and father died or his brother or son were killed before his eyes. Then she tells a story: Odysseus once entered Troy disguised as a beggar, and she alone recognized him, bathed him, and was sworn to silence (4.235–264). Menelaus answers with a counter-story: at the wooden horse, Helen walked around it three times, calling the Achaean chiefs by name and imitating the voices of their wives, and only Odysseus restrained the men from answering (4.266–289).

The drug and the stories are served together. Narrative at Sparta is pharmacological—anaesthetic and toxic at once—and its truth is contested even as it soothes. Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) analyzed writing in the *Phaedrus* as a *pharmakon*, both remedy and poison. The Spartan scene shows that the logic is older than writing: narrative itself is the drug.

The Sirens complete the pharmacology. Their song promises knowledge: "we know all the toils that Argives and Trojans endured in broad Troy by the will of the gods, and we know all that comes to pass on the much-nourishing earth" (12.189–191). They offer the *Iliad* and omniscience, from a meadow heaped with the bones of rotting men (12.45–46). Cicero argued that it was not the sweetness of their voices but their promise of knowledge that held men, and that it was no wonder that knowledge should be dearer than his homeland to a man desirous of wisdom (*quam non erat mirum sapientiae cupido patria esse cariorem*, *De Finibus* 5.49). The Faustian Ulysses of Chapter 9 begins in that sentence.

Kafka's "Das Schweigen der Sirenen" (written 1917) proposes that the Sirens have a more terrible weapon than their song, namely their silence, and that Odysseus, ears stopped and body bound, perhaps did not hear their silence at all—or, being so cunning a fox, noticed it and held up his precautions merely as a shield. Maurice Blanchot's "Le chant des Sirènes" (1959) makes the song the origin of narrative itself and contrasts Ulysses, who hears it safely by technical precaution, with Ahab, who gives himself wholly to the image and is destroyed. Horkheimer and Adorno, as Chapter 2 showed, read the scene as the birth of the concert hall.

The nostic reading differs from all three. Odysseus hears the song of total knowledge only while bound to the mast of a ship that is going home. Contemplative knowledge is permitted under binding to the vector of return. The Sirens offer knowledge as a destination—one stays and dies—and the mast converts it into an experience on the way. Knowledge is not refused; it is subordinated to the limit.

8.6 *Aesthetic Theodicy and the Ethics of Listening*

Seeing his guest weep at the song of Troy, Alcinous asks why he grieves for the fate of the Argives and of Ilion:

> τὸν δὲ θεοὶ μὲν τεῦξαν, ἐπεκλώσαντο δ' ὄλεθρον 579
> ἀνθρώποις, ἵνα ᾖσι καὶ ἐσσομένοισιν ἀοιδή. 580
>
> (8.579–580)

"The gods wrought it, and spun ruin for men, so that there might be song for those yet to come." In the *Iliad*, Helen says that Zeus set an evil fate upon her and Paris so that they might be a theme of song for men hereafter (*Il.* 6.357–358). The idea that suffering exists for the sake of song is the first aesthetic theodicy. Its posterity is distinguished: Nietzsche's declaration that only as an aesthetic phenomenon are existence and the world eternally justified (*Die Geburt der Tragödie* §5, 1872); Mallarmé's claim that everything in the world exists in order to end in a book (1895); Borges's fables of the world as library.

Arendt, in "The Concept of History" (*Between Past and Future*, 1961), made Odysseus weeping at Demodocus' song the paradigmatic scene of the origin of history and poetry. Hearing his own deeds told as a story, the actor confronts their meaning for the first time, and what had been sheer occurrence becomes history. The tears are the hinge between action and narrative.

Aristotle registered the poem's structural intelligence. He praised its unity, noting that Homer did not include every event of Odysseus' life—not, for instance, the wound on Parnassus (*Poetics* 1451a24–29). He reduced its plot to a single sentence: a man long

abroad, watched by Poseidon and alone, while at home suitors waste his property and plot against his son, arrives storm-tossed, reveals himself to some, attacks, and survives while destroying his enemies; the rest is episodes (1455b16–23). He judged it complex and ethical (1459b13–16). And he credited Homer with teaching other poets how to tell lies properly, by false inference, citing the Bath Scene (1460a18–26). The Muses' "false things like true ones" become a doctrine of poetics.

The twentieth century tested the limits of the aesthetic theodicy. The Egyptian sailor's listener had already refused consolation (Chapter 1). Primo Levi, in *Se questo è un uomo* (1947), recorded a dream that recurred among the prisoners of Auschwitz: they are home, telling their story to family and friends, and the listeners do not listen; they speak of other things, they get up and leave. The Phaeacian court is the dream of an audience that listens; the camp's nightmare is its negation. Adorno's dictum that writing poetry after Auschwitz is barbaric (1949; published 1951) questioned whether any aesthetic transfiguration of suffering could be innocent; in *Negative Dialektik* (1966) he partially retracted it, conceding that perennial suffering has as much right to expression as the tortured have to scream.

The *Odyssey*'s aesthetic theodicy can be reread in this light, not as a justification of suffering but as a testimonial ethics. Alcinous' sentence states a fact about the afterlife of suffering—that it becomes song—and the Phaeacian court supplies the condition that makes the fact bearable: a host who listens. The ethics of listening is the *xenia* of testimony, the obligation of the host to receive not only the stranger's body but his story. The spellbound silence (κηληθμός, 11.334; 13.2) in which the Phaeacians sit is the poem's name for the listener's hospitality.

8.7 *The Carrier Bag and the Killer Story*

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986), drawing on Elizabeth Fisher's hypothesis that the first cultural device was a container rather than a weapon, opposes the "killer story" of the hero to the bag, the sling and the net that hold things together. The *Odyssey* is the first container epic. It is full of vessels: Aeolus' bag (10.19–27); the storeroom with its jars of old wine and oil, its gold, bronze and clothing (2.337–347); the chest secured with a knot that Circe taught Odysseus (8.438–448); the Phaeacian gifts hidden in the cave of the nymphs (13.363–371); the beggar's pouch (17.197; 18.108); and Penelope's web, a container woven of time.

Yet the poem's climax reverts to the killer story: the bow, the arrows, the hall running with blood. Its two great arts face each other at its center—the loom, reversible and sustaining, and the bow, irreversible and discharging. The critical nostics proposed in

the Conclusion is Penelopean. It keeps the return and its limit, but takes the loom rather than the bow as its model of how a home is restored.



CHAPTER NINE

The Ulyssean Bifurcation: A Genealogy of the Two Oars

The reception of the *Odyssey* divides along four soteriological vectors—Nostic, Gnostic, Faustian and Apotheotic—and the history of Western thought about limit can be read as the migration of its hero from the first quadrant toward the second and the third, followed in the present by a slow return. This chapter draws the square and traces, in turn, the gnostic, Stoic, Latin, Dantean, Faustian and nostic receptions.

9.1 *The Square*

Two oppositions generate the square introduced in I.4. The first concerns the vector of the journey: return or departure. The second concerns the horizon of home: immanent—earth, body, household, polity—or transcendent—the divine, the intelligible, the posthuman. In Greimas's terms (1966), each pair is a contrariety, and each quadrant is defined by the conjunction of one term from each pair: immanent return (Nostic), transcendent return (Gnostic), immanent departure (Faustian), and transcendent stasis (Apotheotic). Placements below are claims about quadrant only, not about finer position within it.

The Ulyssean Square

four ends to the voyage · 24 placements



FIGURE 15

The Ulyssean Square

Columns divide return from departure; rows divide a transcendent home from an immanent one (9.1). Placements are claims about quadrant only, not about finer position within it.

Read across, the columns divide return from departure; read down, the rows divide a transcendent home from an immanent one. The *Odyssey* stages all four positions as temptations and chooses the lower left; the sections that follow trace how its reception migrated upward and to the right.

9.2 *The Gnostic Odyssey*

Plato keeps the Odyssean form and inverts its valuation. The prisoner of the cave ascends, sees the sun, and must go back down: καταβατέον, "you must descend" (*Republic* 7.520c). The philosopher's return is a duty without desire, and home is above. The doctrine of recollection (*Meno* 81c–86b; *Phaedo* 72e–77a) makes learning a return of the soul to what it knew before birth. Andrea Nightingale (2004) showed that philosophical *theōria* was modeled on civic *theōria*, a journey abroad to witness a sacred spectacle followed by a return home to report it. Philosophy inherited the Odyssean itinerary of departure and return—Herodotus' Solon travels "philosophizing, for the sake of seeing" (1.30.2)—and relocated its home in the intelligible.

Plotinus made the inversion explicit. "Let us flee to the beloved fatherland" (Φεύγωμεν δὴ φίλην ἐς πατρίδα), he writes, quoting a line of Agamemnon from the *Iliad* (2.140): this is the truer counsel. How shall we put out to sea? As Odysseus did, says the poet—speaking in riddles, I think—from Circe the sorceress or Calypso, not content to stay though he had pleasures for the eyes and much sensible beauty. "Our fatherland is that from which we came, and the Father is there" (πατρὶς δὴ ἡμῖν, ὅθεν παρήλθομεν, καὶ πατὴρ ἐκεῖ, *Enneads* 1.6.8). The voyage requires neither feet nor ship nor horses: one must close the eyes and wake another way of seeing. The gnostic Odysseus travels inward, and Circe and Calypso become the sensible world itself.

Porphyry's *On the Cave of the Nymphs* allegorizes the cave at the head of Phorcys' harbor (13.102–112), with its northern entrance for mortals and its southern entrance for gods, as an image of the cosmos and of the soul's descent into generation and ascent from it; the olive beside it figures divine wisdom. In its closing sections Porphyry reads even Teiresias' prophecy in this key: the soul must pass through the sea of generation until it reaches those so free of the sea and its works that they mistake an oar for a winnowing-fan. The Neoplatonists gnosticized the planted oar itself.

The Syriac *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the *Acts of Thomas* (108–113), is a gnostic Odyssey in miniature. A prince is sent from the East to Egypt to retrieve a pearl guarded by a serpent; he puts on Egyptian garments, eats Egyptian food, and forgets both his mission and his origin. His parents send a letter that flies like an eagle and speaks; he awakens, subdues the serpent by pronouncing his father's name, takes the pearl, and returns, to be clothed in a robe in which he sees his own image. The correspondences are

close: the food of forgetting (the lotus, Circe's potion), the divine messenger (Hermes), the garment as *sēma* of the self. The inversions are decisive. The name that saves is the father's, spoken as a spell, where the Odyssean name curses; and home is a transcendent kingdom, while the world is Egypt.

Clement of Alexandria turned the Sirens into the Church's emblem: "Sail past the song; it works death," he urges; "bound to the wood, you will be freed from all corruption; the Word of God will be your pilot (κυβερνήσει σε ὁ λόγος), and the Holy Spirit will bring you to anchor in the harbors of heaven" (*Protrepticus* 12.118). The mast becomes the cross, the Sirens the pleasures of the world, and Odysseus the Christian. Hugo Rahner (1957) traced the motif through the Fathers. Christian salvation re-installs the *kybernētēs* whose absence defined the Phaeacian ship.

Augustine's heart is restless until it rests in God (*Confessions* 1.1). The parable of the prodigal son (Luke 15:11–32) gives the Christian homecoming its form: the father sees his son while he is still far off and runs to embrace him (15:20). Recognition is grace, not proof; return is repentance, not triumph. The Christian nostos abolishes the authentication protocol of Books 16–24, since the father recognizes before any sign.

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) supplies the distinction that separates the nostic from the gnostic. Recollection and repetition, he argues, are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been, and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward. Greek philosophy, with its *anamnēsis*, is recollection; the modern task is repetition. The gnostic return is recollection backward toward an origin. The nostic return is repetition forward: the bed rebuilt in the telling, the marriage consummated anew, the polity re-founded under oath. The *Odyssey*'s homecoming is Kierkegaardian before Kierkegaard.

9.3 *The Stoic and Cynic Odysseus*

Antisthenes' polytropic sage (Chapter 2) also wears a beggar's rags. His surviving speeches for Ajax and Odysseus in the contest for Achilles' arms make the cunning, enduring, ragged Odysseus a Cynic hero, a type later developed by Diogenes and by Dio Chrysostom.

The Roman Stoics moralized the voyage. Horace calls Ulysses a useful exemplar of what virtue and wisdom can do, who resisted the Sirens' voices and Circe's cups, which, drunk foolishly and greedily, would have made him the base and mindless slave of a harlot mistress, living as an unclean dog or a sow that loves the mud (*Epistles* 1.2.17–26). Seneca dismisses the philologists' geography: *quaeris Ulixes ubi erraverit potius quam efficias ne nos semper erremus?*—"you ask where Ulysses wandered, rather than seeing to it that we do not wander forever?" (*Ep.* 88.7). The storms are within, and one must

stop one's ears with something firmer than wax (*Ep.* 31.2). Epictetus admires the hero's endurance but rebukes the tears on Calypso's shore (*Discourses* 3.24). Heraclitus the Allegorist (first century CE) completes the moral allegory: Athena is practical wisdom, the moly is reason, Circe's cup is pleasure (*Homeric Problems* 70–73).

The Stoic Odysseus is a cosmopolitan whose home is the cosmos. Stoicism dissolves the nostic particular into the universal—a gnosticism of reason without transcendence.

9.4 *Latin Mediations and Dante*

The Latin tradition received Ulysses largely through Trojan eyes. Virgil's Ulixes is *dirus* and *scelerum inventor*, the deviser of crimes (*Aeneid* 2.164; 2.261; 2.762). On the Cyclopes' shore Aeneas finds Achaemenides, a Greek companion Odysseus abandoned in his flight, starving and in rags (3.588–691): Virgil's indictment of Odyssean abandonment. Aeneas' own return is a foundation. Italy is the ancient home of his ancestor Dardanus—*antiquam exquirite matrem*, "seek out your ancient mother" (3.96)—so that the new home is a return to an origin never seen: nostos as *translatio*, the colonial homecoming. Ovid stages the contest for Achilles' arms as the triumph of speech over strength (*Metamorphoses* 13.1–398). Cicero, as Chapter 8 showed, made knowledge dearer than homeland to the lover of wisdom (*De Finibus* 5.49).

Out of these materials Dante built his Ulysses (*Inferno* 26.90–142). The hero speaks from a forked flame among the fraudulent counselors. After leaving Circe, he says,

> né dolcezza di figlio, né la pieta
> del vecchio padre, né 'l debito amore
> lo qual dovea Penelopè far lieta,
> vincer potero dentro a me l'ardore
> ch'i' ebbi a divenir del mondo esperto
> e de li vizi umani e del valore.
>
> (26.94–99)

"Neither the sweetness of a son, nor reverence for an aged father, nor the due love that should have gladdened Penelope, could conquer within me the ardor I had to gain experience of the world, and of human vices and worth." The three persons Dante's Ulysses renounces—son, aged father, wife—are precisely the three whose recognition scenes constitute the second half of Homer's poem: Telemachus in Book 16, Penelope in Book 23, Laertes in Book 24. Without having read the *Odyssey*, Dante negates its structure term by term.

The rest follows. The Pillars of Heracles were set "so that man should go no further" (acciò che l'uom più oltre non si metta, 26.109). Ulysses addresses his aging crew in

a little oration: "consider your origin: you were not made to live like brutes, but to follow virtue and knowledge" (fatti non foste a viver come bruti, / ma per seguir virtute e canoscenza, 26.118–120). They make wings of their oars for the mad flight (26.125); after five months beyond the Pillars a dark mountain appears; a whirlwind from the new land strikes the prow, whirls the ship three times, raises the stern on the fourth, "as pleased Another," until the sea closes over them (26.136–142).

The oration repays attention. Its argument takes the Circean fear—of becoming beasts—and turns it into the motive for transgression: to avoid being a brute one must sail beyond the limit. The humanist argument against bestialization becomes an argument against limit itself.

Dante could not read Homer. Greek was effectively inaccessible in Italy until Leontius Pilatus made a Latin prose translation of Homer for Boccaccio and Petrarch in the 1360s, decades after the *Commedia*. Dante's Ulysses was assembled from Virgil, Ovid, Cicero, Horace, Seneca and Statius. The Faustian Ulysses is a creation of Latin mediation: a reading of the hero by those who could not read his poem (Stanford 1954; Boitani 1992).

Primo Levi's chapter "Il canto di Ulisse" (*Se questo è un uomo*, 1947) is the most searching modern reception of the canto. Levi, an Italian Jewish chemist arrested as a partisan in December 1943, was deported in February 1944 to Auschwitz, the camp complex Nazi Germany built in occupied Poland, where the SS murdered about 1.1 million people, roughly a million of them Jews; most of those deported with him were killed on arrival. Carrying the soup ration through the camp with a young Alsatian prisoner called Pikolo, Levi tries to recite and translate the canto from memory. At "fatti non foste a viver come bruti" he hears the lines as if for the first time, like a trumpet blast; he would give the day's soup to recover the lines he has lost; and at the final verse he glimpses something gigantic he has only now understood. What Homer's Circe works with a drug, and what Dante's Ulysses names as a temptation, was in Auschwitz a policy carried out by people: the SS regime of starvation, forced labor, numbering and selection for the gas chambers, which set out to reduce prisoners to brutes. Levi makes recited poetry a counter-moly against it. Remembering the canto becomes an act of survival: the lotus inverted.

9.5 *Plus Ultra: The Faustian Modern*

The warning of the Pillars, *non plus ultra*, became, inverted, the device of Charles V, *Plus Ultra*, adopted around 1516; it remains on the Spanish coat of arms. Under that device Hernán Cortés conquered the Aztec empire (1519–1521) and Francisco Pizarro the Inca empire (from 1532), and in the following century the Indigenous population

of the Americas collapsed through war, forced labor under the *encomienda* system and, above all, epidemic disease. The motto of the Faustian Ulysses was, in its first imperial use, the motto of a conquest. Francis Bacon's *Instauratio Magna* (1620) bears an engraved title-page on which a ship sails out between the Pillars of Hercules, beneath the motto from Daniel 12:4, *Multi pertransibunt et augebitur scientia*—"many shall pass through, and knowledge shall be increased." The new science announced itself as Dante's Ulysses vindicated. Horkheimer and Adorno begin the *Dialectic of Enlightenment* with Bacon.

Even the reading of Homer acquired the imagery of conquest. Keats, "On First Looking into Chapman's Homer" (1816), compares the experience of the translation to an astronomer's discovery and a conquistador's first sight of an ocean: "Then felt I like some watcher of the skies / When a new planet swims into his ken; / Or like stout Cortez when with eagle eyes / He star'd at the Pacific." The first European to see the Pacific from the Isthmus of Darién, in 1513, was Vasco Núñez de Balboa; Keats's slip gives the moment to the conqueror of Mexico, fusing discovery with conquest.

Goethe showed the cost. In the fifth act of *Faust*, Part Two (1832), Faust, now a developer reclaiming land from the sea, covets the cottage of the old couple Philemon and Baucis—Ovid's paragons of hospitality, who received the gods unawares—and Mephistopheles' men burn it, killing them. Marshall Berman (1982) read the episode as the tragedy of development. The Faustian vector is not only the transgression of the limit but the destruction of *xenia*.

Tennyson's "Ulysses" (1842), drawn from Dante rather than Homer, despises the Homeric home: "It little profits that an idle king, / By this still hearth, among these barren crags, / Match'd with an aged wife, I mete and dole / Unequal laws unto a savage race." His hero yearns "to follow knowledge like a sinking star, / Beyond the utmost bound of human thought," and ends "to strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield."

Melville's *Moby-Dick* (1851) splits the figure in two. Ahab is the Dantean Ulysses, a monomaniac captain who drives his crew past every limit in pursuit of the white whale and whose ship goes down in a vortex: "then all collapsed, and the great shroud of the sea rolled on as it rolled five thousand years ago." Ishmael is the Homeric survivor, the only one of the crew to escape, floating on Queequeg's coffin turned life-buoy—a tomb become a raft—beneath the epigraph from Job: "And I only am escaped alone to tell thee." Odysseus, too, is the sole survivor of his crew, riding a lashed keel and mast (12.420–425), and lives to tell. Blanchot's pairing of Ulysses and Ahab is already Melville's.

Nietzsche wrote the Faustian manifesto against nostos. "We have left the land and gone aboard ship! We have burned our bridges behind us—more, we have broken down the land behind us," he wrote, adding a warning: woe if homesickness for the

land should overcome you, as if there had been more freedom there, "and there is no longer any 'land'" (*Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §124, 1882). Elsewhere he exhorts: *Auf die Schiffe, ihr Philosophen!*—"to the ships, you philosophers!" (§289). Nietzsche is the philosopher of the burned shore.

Nikos Kazantzakis' *Odyssey: A Modern Sequel* (1938) carries the vector to its terminus. In 33,333 lines, Odysseus, restless after the massacre, leaves Ithaca again, passes through Sparta, Crete and Egypt, founds an ideal city in Africa that an earthquake destroys, becomes an ascetic, and dies in the polar ice. The voyage without return ends in white silence.

9.6 *The Nostic Counter-Tradition*

The nostic quadrant survived as a counter-voice, often in exile. Joachim du Bellay, homesick in Rome, wrote in *Les Regrets* (1558) the sonnet that begins *Heureux qui, comme Ulysse, a fait un beau voyage*—"happy he who, like Ulysses, has made a fine voyage ... and then returned, full of experience and reason, to live among his kin the rest of his days"—and preferred his little Liré to the Palatine (sonnet 31). The Renaissance nostic speaks in the same generation as *Plus Ultra*.

German thought made homecoming the essence of philosophy. Novalis wrote that philosophy is really homesickness, the urge to be at home everywhere (*Die Philosophie ist eigentlich Heimweh—Trieb überall zu Hause zu seyn*, *Das Allgemeine Brouillon*, 1798–99). Lukács opened *The Theory of the Novel* (1916; 1920) with the sentence and defined the novel as the form of "transcendental homelessness" (*transzendentale Obdachlosigkeit*), the epic as the form of a world that was home. Heidegger began his lecture course on the fundamental concepts of metaphysics (1929–30) with the same words, and later named homelessness the destiny of the world (*Brief über den Humanismus*, 1946). Hegel declared that at the name of Greece the educated European, and the German especially, feels at home (*heimatlich*): Greece itself became philosophy's Ithaca. Ernst Bloch closed *Das Prinzip Hoffnung* (1954–59) by naming as *Heimat* something that shines into everyone's childhood and where no one has yet been. Home moves from the past into the future, and the utopian nostos bridges the Nostic and the Gnostic.

Joyce's *Ulysses* (1922) is the most thoroughgoing modern nostic text. Bloom's day ends with a return to the bed. In "Ithaca," the catechism names him "Everyman or Noman"—Outis universalized. In "Cyclops," the one-eyed nationalism of the Citizen hurls a biscuit tin. The homecoming takes place without a massacre: Bloom's feelings toward his wife's lover proceed through "envy, jealousy, abnegation, equanimity." The suitors are not slain but absorbed into equanimity. Bloom and Stephen contemplate

"the heaventree of stars hung with humid nightblue fruit," cosmic scale and domestic return in one chapter, and Molly's monologue ends "yes I said yes I will Yes." Joyce keeps the bed and discards the bow.

Cavafy's "Ithaka" (1911) occupies the border. Ithaka gave you the beautiful voyage, the poem says; without her you would not have set out; she has nothing more to give you, and if you find her poor, she has not deceived you. The destination's value lies in its having generated the journey: a processual nostos at the edge between the Nostic and the Faustian.

The twentieth century's strongest objections to the nostic—Levinas' Abraham and Adorno's bourgeois—were answered in Chapters 2 and 3. Its strongest revisions come from the margins of the poem: Walcott's Caribbean Homer (1990), Atwood's maids (2005), Mason's variant books (2010), Wilson's translation (2017), and Miller's goddess who chooses death (2018).

9.7 *Reading the Map*

The *Odyssey* is the only text examined that occupies all four quadrants—as temptations—while choosing one. Ancient philosophical reception moved its hero toward the Gnostic quadrant (Plato, Plotinus, Clement). The Latin West, lacking the poem, moved him into the Faustian quadrant (Cicero, Dante), where early modernity made him its emblem (Charles V, Bacon, Goethe, Tennyson, Nietzsche). The Nostic quadrant survived as a counter-voice (du Bellay, Voltaire, Joyce, Cavafy) and is now reviving (Le Guin, Robinson, Walcott, Atwood, Miller), as the Faustian horizon meets its ecological limit and the Apotheotic offer returns in technological form. The Conclusion returns to the poem's own answer: the planted oar.



CONCLUSION

The Planted Oar: Toward a Critical Nostics

The *Odyssey*'s final word on the human is an oar driven into a field: the instrument of departure converted, by a stranger's misreading, into the sign of an end freely accepted. This conclusion reads the prophecy closely, joins it to Elpenor's tomb and to the poem's three endings, and draws from the whole argument a critical nostics—an ethics of limit purged of the poem's own purge.

C.1 *The Sign That Is a Misreading*

Teiresias' oar is εὐῆρες ἐρετμόν, "well-fitted" (11.121), and four lines later the poem names such oars wings to ships (11.125). The people to whom it must be carried "do not know the sea and eat no food mixed with salt" (11.122–123). Salt, the sea's residue in human food, marks the limit of the maritime world. The saltless land is the sailor's absolute elsewhere—not monstrous, like the Cyclopes, who also lack ships (9.125–129), but agricultural and at peace.

The sign is introduced by a formula: σῆμα δέ τοι ἐρέω μάλ' ἀριφραδές, οὐδέ σε λήσει, "I will tell you a sign, very clear, and it will not escape you" (11.126). The same verse introduces, in the *Iliad*, the turning-post of the chariot race, which Nestor says may be "the mound of some mortal long dead," or a goal set up by men of former times

(*Il.* 23.326; 23.331–332). Gregory Nagy (1983) showed that the Iliadic passage fuses three senses of *sēma*: sign, tomb, and the turning-point around which the chariot must wheel in order to come back. Teiresias imports that whole structure into the *Odyssey*'s end. The sign Odysseus will recognize is the turning-post of his life, and it is a tomb. The negated verb of concealment—οὐδέ σε λήσει—completes the poem's aletheiology (Chapter 2): its last sign cannot be missed.

The sign consists in a misnaming. A wayfarer will say that Odysseus carries on his shoulder an ἀθηρηλοιγός, a "chaff-destroyer" (11.128), a compound found only here and in its repetition in Book 23. In a land without the sea, the oar's form is legible only as a tool of grain. Then the rite: καὶ τότε δὴ γαίῃ πήξας εὐῆρες ἐρετμόν, "and then, fixing the well-fitted oar in the earth" (11.129), sacrifice a ram, a bull and a boar to Poseidon (11.130–131)—reconciliation with the god of the sea, performed where no one knows the sea—return home, and offer hecatombs to all the gods in order (11.132–134). Then:

θάνατος δέ τοι ἐξ ἁλὸς αὐτῷ 134
ἀβληχρὸς μάλα τοῖος ἐλεύσεται, ὅς κέ σε πέφνῃ 135
γήραϊ ὕπο λιπαρῷ ἀρημένον· ἀμφὶ δὲ λαοὶ 136
ὄλβιοι ἔσσονται. 137

(11.134–137)

"Death will come to you *ex halos*, very gentle, such as will take you worn out by sleek old age; and around you your people will be prosperous."

In Book 23, Odysseus tells the prophecy to Penelope in their bedchamber (23.264–284). She answers that if the gods will grant a better old age, there is hope of escape from evils (23.286–287). Only then do they come gladly "to the rite of their old bed" (ἀσπάσιοι λέκτροιο παλαιοῦ θεσμὸν ἵκοντο, 23.296)—the verse that Aristarchus and Aristophanes of Byzantium, according to the scholia, called the end of the *Odyssey*.

C.2 *Elpenor's Oar and the Cenotaph of the Sailor*

The poem plants an oar once before. Elpenor, the youngest companion, fell drunk from Circe's roof and broke his neck (10.552–560). His shade, the first to meet Odysseus in Hades, begs for burial with his arms and a mound by the grey sea, a sign for men to come, and adds: πῆξαί τ' ἐπὶ τύμβῳ ἐρετμόν, τῷ καὶ ζωὸς ἔρεσσον ἐὼν μετ' ἐμοῖς ἑτάροισιν—"and fix upon the mound the oar with which I rowed in life among my companions" (11.75–78). Back on Aeaea, the companions burn him and fix the well-fitted oar on the top of the mound (12.13–15).

The two planted oars are bound by the verb (πήγνυμι) and by the epithet (εὐῆρες). Elpenor's marks a sailor's grave beside the sea; Odysseus' will be planted far from it. The first is a *sēma* for a dead man. The second is a *sēma* that a living man erects for the sailor he has been.

Odysseus' planted oar is therefore the cenotaph of his maritime self. The sēmatic self of Chapter 3 ends by authoring its own sign: the man whose identity was distributed among signs held by others performs, as his last voluntary act, the setting-up of a sign that marks the end of a way of being. He buries the voyager while alive. Dante's Ulysses receives no tomb and no sign; the sea simply closes over him (*Inferno* 26.142). Melville's Ishmael survives on a coffin turned into a raft. Homer's Odysseus raises the tomb himself and walks home from it.

C.3 *Meaning as Use; Winnowing as Krisis*

The misnaming of the oar is a lesson in semantics. Wittgenstein compared words to the tools in a toolbox, whose functions are as diverse as theirs (*Philosophical Investigations* §11), and held that for a large class of cases the meaning of a word is its use in the language (§43). The oar has no essence that travels with it. In a form of life without the sea, it is a winnowing-fan. The saltless land is the boundary of a form of life, and the sign that ends the voyage is the moment the voyager's instrument loses its language.

The misreading is also a transformation. A winnowing-fan separates grain from chaff. In the *Iliad*, chaff is carried across the threshing-floors "when blonde Demeter separates (κρίνῃ) the grain from the chaff in the driving winds" (*Il.* 5.499–502). The verb *krinein*, to sift, to separate, is the root of *krisis* and of criticism. The oar ends as an instrument of discernment. The end of adventure is the beginning of judgment: the voyager's tool becomes the critic's.

The Gospels made the same instrument the emblem of final judgment: the one who is coming has his winnowing-fan in his hand, will clear his threshing-floor, gather the wheat into the granary and burn the chaff (Matthew 3:12; Luke 3:17). The planted oar points toward judgment too, but in the *Odyssey* the judgment is human—discernment exercised within a finite life—rather than the separation of the saved from the damned.

C.4 *The Telegonic Shadow*

The phrase ἐξ ἁλός (11.134) can mean "away from the sea" or "out of the sea." The ancient sequel took the second sense literally. In the *Telegony*, Odysseus is killed by his son by Circe, and later sources specify a spear tipped with the spine of a stingray (Apollodorus, *Epitome* 7.36); a fragment of Aeschylus' *Psychagogoi* has Teiresias foretell

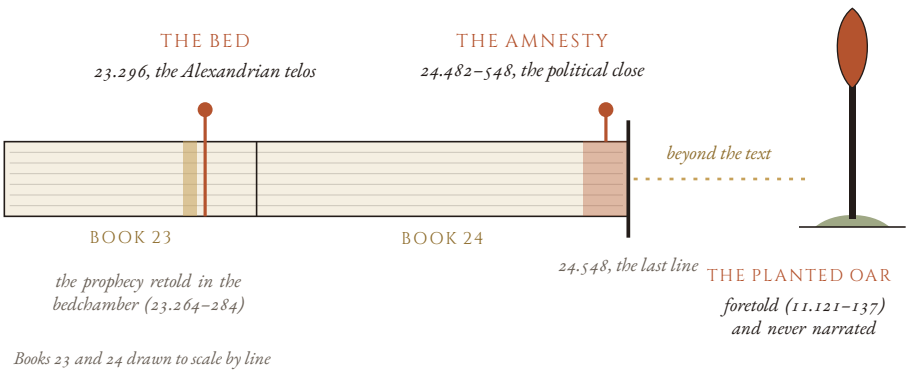


FIGURE 16

Three endings

The bed, the amnesty, and the planted oar that lies beyond the last line (C.5).

a death caused by a sea-creature's spine dropped by a heron. The *Odyssey* itself leaves the phrase open. John Peradotto (1990) called Teiresias' speech a prophecy "degree zero," whose future remains undetermined within the poem.

Elected finitude therefore includes the acceptance of not knowing the manner of one's end. The nostic choice is not the purchase of a guaranteed good death; it is assent to a finite life whose closure remains ambiguous even in prophecy.

C.5 *Three Endings*

The poem ends three times. It ends in the bed (23.296), the Alexandrian telos. It ends in the amnesty (24.482–548), its political close. And it ends in the planted oar, which lies outside the narrated text, in a future the poem announces and never narrates. The philosophical end of the *Odyssey* lies beyond its last line—fittingly, for a poem whose central claim is that a life is defined by an end it can choose but cannot narrate from within.

C.6 *Toward a Critical Nostics*

The nostic ontology reconstructed in these chapters yields five ethical principles.

I Elected finitude. Limit is the condition of meaning: a good is recognizable as a good only within a horizon of possible loss (Chapter 4).

II Sēmatic responsibility. The self is held in others' keeping; we owe them the preservation of their signs, and recognition requires shared time (Chapter 3).

III Opacity and the gift of the name. The stranger may withhold identity until fed, and the name is given to those who have earned it (Chapters 2 and 7).

IV Hospitality before identification, and listening as hospitality. The host owes the stranger nourishment before interrogation and attention to the stranger's story (Chapters 7 and 8).

V The planted oar. The voluntary consecration of the end of expansion is not a refusal of the voyage but the knowledge of when a voyage is over (Conclusion).

The critical qualification is indispensable. The poem's own restoration is purgative, patriarchal and slaveholding, and it is sealed by imposed oblivion (Chapter 7). A critical nostics keeps the planted oar and refuses the purge of the bow, but its models cannot be lifted from the poem intact. Eumaeus, the dispossessed man who is the poem's most perfect host, is also one of the three men who drive the twelve women to their deaths and mutilate Melanthius (22.457–477); Telemachus, whose coming of age the poem narrates, chooses the rope. Even the gentlest figures share in the purge. A critical nostics therefore takes what it needs selectively: Penelope's loom, which restores by re-weaving, reversibly and patiently; Eumaeus' hospitality without his part in the killing; Joyce's Bloom, who returns without a massacre; Atwood's maids, who testify; and Miller's goddess, who elects finitude from above.

The planted oar itself points the way. The last stranger in the *Odyssey*'s future is neither slain, nor feared, nor converted. He simply misnames the oar, and his misnaming is received as a sign. The final encounter with otherness is a peaceful misrecognition, sanctified by sacrifice.

C.7 *Untimely Relevance*

The *Odyssey*'s questions have returned in technological form. Calypso's offer returns as the project of radical life-extension, and the dispute between Bostrom and Hägglund is a dispute about Ogygia. The Phaeacian ship returns as artificial systems designed to model the intentions of their users. The poem's automation paradox (7.103–107; 20.105–119) warns that thinking machines at the top need not emancipate the grinding women at the bottom, and its petrified ship recalls that the threshold technologies of one age may be sealed by the next.

Outis returns in the politics of data and identity—anonymity, verification, synthetic impersonation—where the poem's many-factored authentication under perfect visual

deception is newly instructive. The Pillars of Heracles return as planetary boundaries, in attempts to define a safe operating space for humanity (Rockström et al. 2009) and in Hans Jonas' imperative of responsibility for a technological civilization (1979).

None of this makes the Faustian vector simply wrong. It produced science, medicine, and much of what makes modern life humane, and a nostic ethics is not an ethics against voyaging: Odysseus voyaged, and the planted oar consecrates the end of a voyage, not the refusal to begin one. Nor is nostalgia innocent; restorative nostalgia has fueled exclusion and violence, as the poem's own hall testifies. What the *Odyssey* offers is not a doctrine but a structure of judgment: when to sail, when to listen, when to plant the oar.

C.8 *Coda*

Somewhere inland, among people who have never tasted salt, an oar stands upright in a field. A passing stranger calls it a winnowing-fan. The old man who carried it accepts the name, sacrifices to the god of a sea no one there has seen, and turns home to wait for a gentle death among a prosperous people. The instrument of flight has become an instrument of judgment; the wing has become a sign.

The human being, on the *Odyssey*'s account, is the animal that knows where to plant its oar.

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THE PLANTED OAR

Nostic Ontology, Sēmatic Selfhood, and the Ethics of Elected Finitude in Homer's Odyssey *and Its Speculative Afterlives*

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